



VINOBA IN PAKISTAN



Charu Chowdhari

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By
Charu Choudhury

SARVA SEVA SANGH PRAKASHAN

RAJGHAT, VARANASI
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PUBLISHERS' NOTE

After the Padyatra of a year and a half in Assam, Vinoba passed through E. Pakistan enroute to West Bengal. He was in Pakistan for 16 days, entering on 5th September '62 and leaving on 21st September '62. Shree Charu Chowdhari, a zealous Sarvodaya worker of that country who accompanied him, records in this book the speeches that Vinoba made there and important events connected with this tour. The message of love that Vinoba carried, found a spontaneous response among the people. His speeches are marked with catholicity and cover a wide range of subjects. It is characteristic of Vinoba that whether he speaks on national or international affairs, science or spirituality, village or world he weaves his thoughts in such simple words that even the most unsophisticated can understand him. He appeals to the higher instincts of man and tries to draw out the best in him. To whatever race, religion, nationality, or language a man may belong, he touches the human and universal in him. That is the secret of his success and the portent of things to come.

The book has been translated from the Hindi Version by Shri Dilip of Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan.

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A hearty welcome in Pakistan.



Addressing a public meeting at Bhurangamari.



Raiganj : Vinoba Chatting with Press Correspondents.



Towards Kudigram : His day begins at 3 A. M.

I

THE FIRST IMPACT

The first day.

On this side of the border in Assam, Vinoba finished his parting speech, got down from the rostrum and walked into East Pakistan at Sonarhat. The Deputy Commissioner of Rangpur, Mr. Yaqoob Ali Khan received him on the threshold in a simple ceremony of untying the rope at the dividing line. Thus his love's labour began.

After a time he walked ahead, caught hold of two children by the hand, and hand in hand he almost began to race. I had been left behind and could overtake him only by running. "We are to halt a bit here in the school compound of Sonarhat," I interrupted. We went there and got surrounded by a crowd of students and people. Vinoba made his first speech here after his entry into Pakistan. He began with the expression of hearty thanks to the Pakistan govt. for permitting him to enter East Pakistan. Continuing he said, "I have come here with a message of love and peace for the people of Pakistan. Only after 5 minutes of my coming here a friend had asked me how I felt here. I replied that I did not feel different at all--the same air, the same earth, the same men and the same hearts--there was no difference. My heart is brimming with love at the sight of you all, just as it would react at the sight of children, men and women in India. To my mind the whole world is mine and I am the servant of humanity. Wheresoever I go, my slogan is 'Victory to the world', i.e. the whole world is one, all are one." Kalindi Bahin makes a note in her diary: There were two child-

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ren in this meeting about twelve years in age, with tattered clothes on, lathi in hand, seated in a majestic pose like a king. Last night both of them came to visit the Saint. I had seen them yesterday at the border and today among the people of Pakistan hearing Vinoba with rapt attention. A walk of eight miles. It drizzled on the way. At intervals, Baba would hold the children by the hand and run. An hour back he had said, "It is the same air, same earth." The sight of people's reception of Baba provoked in me the thought, 'The same faith, the same words'.

The very evening, at 4 P.M. a public meeting was held in the school premises. About 4-5 thousand people had gathered spontaneously, as if the whole atmosphere was surcharged with the news of Vinoba's arrival. They heard him with rapt attention. He said:

"Perhaps you know that I have been on foot-march for about the last eleven years and a half. The distance between this place and Karachi can be covered within a few hours by plane. Why am I then moving on foot in this age of science? It is with a purpose. A large number of people live in villages and have no contact with the outer world. When there are floods they are completely cut off. How shall I meet them if I travel by air? That is why I cover the distance on foot.

I have visited the whole of India, gone to all the States if not to all the districts. When the question of going from Assam to W. Bengal arose, the idea of visiting Pakistan occurred to me. So I asked for permission of the Pakistan Govt. which they so kindly accorded. They might have thought, 'This faquir is a servant of the poor and always talks of alleviating their misery.' And so they permitted me to pass through this wing of Pakistan. I can not describe how pleased I am in meeting you. There was good rain on the way, but I came through it playing with

the children. It was not at all uncomfortable to me. The rain drops appeared to me to be God's blessings. In you I am having God's 'Darshan'. I have been experiencing the joy of such 'Darshan' for the last twelve years. I have to walk even in this old age, but my enthusiasm does not wane. Why? It is because I present the case of the poor before the prosperous. I tell those who roll in prosperity to alleviate the pangs of those who wallow in misery. It is a pleasure to feed the hungry, but they will get hungry again. They will have to be re-fed. Will it be a real solution of the problem? No, they should be provided with the *means of livelihood*. Therefore I have been appealing to people every-where to share a part of their land with the needy. In this way I got in donation 40 lakh acres of land which is being distributed among the landless. There is a delight of giving. In my childhood a jack tree (Katahal) in our house bore fruits which were distributed first among the neighbours at the instance of my mother. Only after that, we partook of them. I was so much filled with the joy of sharing that even today the memory of that event gladdens my heart. Everybody has this experience more or less that one gets more pleasure in feeding others rather than oneself.

It is said that East Pakistan has not got sufficient land. According to the census of 1951, there were 777 people per sq. mile; today the figure may be 900. But in Kerala State, it is 1400 per sq. mile and inspite of that I received plenty of land in donation there.

Share your income with the poor

I have come to this country empty-handed and shall return so. But if the work of Bhoodan begins in Pakistan, it will forge unity among millions. Friendship, love, compassion and service of the distressed—this is the essence of religions. It

has been said in the Quran, 'Share your income with others'. The Vedas have also said in the same vein. Christianity also says, 'Share your property with the deprived'. Thus every religion advocates charity. If you donate land, you will have God's blessings, the recipient will have the benefit of the land, and myself, a 'faquir', will have the satisfaction of such a result. All are equal in the eyes of God, none high, none low. The rich and the poor alike were born naked, they will also die naked. After death, the body will turn into dust or ashes, it won't be gold or silver in the case of the rich. All are equal in the eyes of God, but it is we who introduce the divisions of high and low in our egotism. In some there is vanity of wealth, in some others vanity of caste. We remember God as 'kind and merciful'. If He is kind, how can we become cruel? How shall we be worthy of His mercy if we are not moved by the misery of others or make distinction of high and low in our dealings with others? It is the supreme duty to love all equally, to serve all. All the rest is of secondary importance. Animals and birds cannot speak, while we can; and so we must speak the truth only, talk of love and recite the name of God and nothing else. Now I shall join with you in remembering the name of God for five minutes. This is a gathering of men and women, old and young, Hindus and Muslims, Christians and the rest. But it is unfortunate that we get divided at the time of reciting the name of God. We participate in a number of joint efforts but not so in offering prayers. Is this God such that we must divide into separate groups while reciting His name? In what language shall we remember Him? Some do it in Sanskrit, some in Arabic, some in English and some in another language. I shall remember Him in the language of the heart. After keeping silent, we shall recite His name in the language of our choice. What shall we pray for? We shall

pray for granting us truth, love, mercy. Now let us pray in silence. Om Shantih ! Shantih !! Shantih !!! (Peace ! Peace !! Peace !!!).”

The whole audience sat spell-bound. It was a unique sight. After the silent prayer, Vinoba addressing them said, “ Good-night to all, Jai Jagat.”

He then got up and walked from one end of the compound to the other, and then the people dispersed slowly.

After the prayer when Vinoba was sitting in the house, several prominent persons of the village came to him. Vinoba asked if some one could recite from the Holy Quran. A gentleman acceded to his wish and he kept on hearing quietly. Thereafter he addressed them, “ You fed me and looked after me. I am only a day’s guest and every body feeds his guest. But my appeal to you is that you should share a part of your land with the landless. Give in donation. You may have consultations among yourselves. Those who donate land will themselves choose the donatory, the only condition being that the beneficiary should be one who is landless and has no title to the land by way of inheritance.”

The first Bhoodan in Pakistan

Most of the visitors had left. The day was at its end, night was setting in as if ushering the goddess of wealth. Baba’s appeal had stirred the soul of a gentleman who came and said that he had in all four acres of land and several dependents and yet he would donate one bigha to a landless person. When the donation deed was being written, he said, “ No, not one bigha, let it be one acre. For nothing less than that will serve the beneficiary’s purpose. He has no land even to reside on.” In the Dan-patra was written the name of the donor and one acre as donation ; ~~it was also~~ mentioned that the sum of Rs. 12/-,

being the registration fee, would also be paid by the donor. Baba lovingly put his hand on the shoulder of the donor and said, "I shall pray to God to bless you." This moved the gentleman to tears. A purifying sight ! Referring to this Baba exclaimed, "The doors have opened." Ashadevi remarked, "We received our first Bhoodan at Pocham Palli on 18th April, 1951, and in E. Pakistan on 5th September '62. So far Baba talked of Bhoodan, only in India. Today the doors have been opened for it out of India too."

This first Gramdan has a special merit. It is purified with the tears of sympathy shown for a poor man by another, none too wealthier. ●

5 Sep., 1962

II

A CALL TO WOMEN

The second day.

Baba set out on his journey exactly at 4 A.M. Our next camp was the school building of Raiganj. Kalindi writes in her diary :

After the wash, Baba took his seat in the open, below a tree. People surrounded him. Some of the Govt. officials, members of the security force and press correspondents had an interview with Baba. A correspondent asked, "What is the object of your foot-march?" Quick came the reply, "To convey the message of love." This gave rise to a supplementary question, "To whom?" Baba laughed and replied, "To all. I love even these trees." Kalindi's diary goes on :

I was eager about the evening meeting. What will Baba speak today? We reached the venue of the meeting at 4 P.M. The loud-speaker had gone out of order. How will a gathering of thousands hear him? Baba got down from the rostrum and went right to the middle, followed by Ashadevi; with a frail body and hand raised, he began to address the meeting a bit loudly. There was pin-drop silence. Even little children were quiet.

It was a gathering of about four thousand people. The speech began :

"I shall have to speak without the aid of the mike. It is not in order. This village is small, yet a large number have attended the meeting. But it pains me that ladies did not come. Had they come, the size of the audience would be double. At Bhurungamari, when I asked a gentleman if ladies could not

attend the meeting, he replied that they could if arrangements had been made in advance. I want to convey my message of love. God has bestowed on them too, the gift of hearing. They also should hear the message of peace, of love just like their brothers. Ashadevi who is moving with me, has travelled far and wide and is now interpreting to you what I speak. Like her, other ladies also can attend the meeting." Continuing he referred to Bhoodan made at Bhurungamari and said, "At the mouth, the river is shallow and narrow. As it flows further down, it gathers in size and volume. The river of Bhoodan has begun to flow, and can grow in size later on if you open the gates of your heart. This noon the chairman of a Union Council came and gave five Bighas of land in Bhoodan. Subsequently two more donors came.

The pleasure of giving

God has given us this human body. To eat, to fall ill, to die is common to birds and animals too; if they do not get food they have to remain hungry; they never keep fast voluntarily. But man fasts of his own free will and takes pleasure in it. Similarly it pleases him to give in charity. This tendency should grow. I do not know how long I shall live. Very soon I am to complete my 67th year. No wonder if I die this very night. All are mortal. Then how will an owner own after death? Were it possible to carry land with oneself after death, I would say, 'Both the land and the owner are there.' But really speaking only God is the owner.

It is argued that the population here is thick. But I received thousands of Dan-patras in Kerala where the population figure is as high as 1,400 per sq. mile, much higher than that of this part. This had been possible because the people there were generous. If there are five persons in a family and food available

is just sufficient only for four, will only four partake of it and say to the fifth, 'There is no food for you, You will get when more is made available?' No, they all will share the food together. This is what we call the family spirit. This is real humanity, real religion. I shall not speak more now. Let us now remember God for five minutes—Him whose children we all are. Let us pray in the language of the heart in which all languages merge—of the educated and the uneducated, the rich and the poor, men and women, Hindus and Muslims. What shall we pray for? Not for land, wealth etc. We shall say, 'Grant us truth, love, kindness.' Thus saying he raised his hand, recited 'Fatiha' in musical tone and closed his speech with Peace ! Peace !! Peace !!!”

An enchantment swayed over the people. In silence they prayed. After a short time, Vinoba bowed, shouted 'Jai Jagat' and came out of the crowd and retired to one end of the field, below a tree. But there was a long line of people still coming in; they thought the meeting would continue till late at night and so were now coming after the day's work had been over. So he again walked to the gathering at 5-30 P.M. and addressed them for a few minutes. The gist of his speech was as under :

“We got three donations of land today. I move with a few companions from village to village every day, passing not more than a day anywhere. I am a stranger and cannot even speak your language. Could I do so, I would have myself gone from house to house and explained my message to you. If the local workers had tried to collect Bhoodan by convincing you, I am sure we would have received 20 donations.” When he had resumed his seat, two more donations were declared, making a total of five for the day. ●

III

THE VILLAGE RECONSTRUCTION—THE SOURCE OF STRENGTH

The third day.

A short while before 7 A.M. we arrived at Nageshwari. We were camped in the High School building. About 7 to 8 hundred people had gathered. Addressing them Vinoba said, "Today is my third day in Pakistan. I have come here to extend love to you and also receive from you. This has been my pursuit for about the last 12 years and will continue till the end.

This is an age of science. The people of a country can get strong with its help. But to attain that object, the village has first to get strong. Village is the main-stay of the country. Village is our first storey, district the second, state the third and country the fourth. Nageshwari village is the first storey, Rangpur the second, Dacca the third and Karachi the fourth. If the lowermost storey is weak, on what will the topmost rest? That is why the lower-most has to be made strong. If the villagers are ill-nourished, children are not provided with milk and butter, if all are weak and the cattle population is semi-starved, then this will adversely affect the food production. From where will Rangpur, Dacca and Karachi get food?

Today the villages are not villages in the true sense, they are mere jumbles of houses. When the villagers produce wealth and have collective strength, real villages will come into being. You may say that Pakistan has about 1½ lacs of villages, but I don't see even a single village; they are mere conglomerations of

houses. When they muster a united force, they will be called villages in the right sense. Such a village is yet to be born. Had there been such villages in existence, none would have to get into debts at the time of marriages of one's sons and daughters. Take for example, a small village where four marriages are to be celebrated—of course in different families. In a village of my conception, the ceremony could be performed in all the cases on the same day—thus less expenditure will be incurred, no debt will be necessary and you will have more enjoyment. Even marriages of Hindu and Muslim families can be celebrated on the same day if there is mutual love. Such an orientation of the village will weave it into one family, strong and healthy.

There are a number of villages which are not approachable except by walking. And so I walk and can visit even the smallest village along with bigger ones as well as cities, which fall on the way.

Some say that I am a man of learning and it will be difficult to follow what I say. But my talks are so simple that even small children sitting here will be able to grasp what I say.

At Bhurungamari a muslim youth gave in donation one acre out of his four acres of land. The next day at Raiganj there were five donors. In India, 40 lac acres of land have been obtained in Bhoodan of which 10 lac acres have been allotted to the landless and the distribution is going on. I trust that here too the landowners will show generosity, and the movement will get momentum. So long as I am in Pakistan, the message of love will be carried relentlessly. I don't think of the future. The river never thinks of its future when at its source. In the same way the stream of love will flow, it may even over-flow. May it be so, for the love-floods will do harm to none, they will benefit all."

Addressing the children he said,

“You have understood what I said. Is it not? Will you convey this message of Bhoodan to your mother? Tell her: ‘A Faquir has asked for land for the poor.’ She may reply, ‘Dear child, the land is for you.’ Then you can tell her, ‘There are children like us even in the families of the poor. They play with us. Their want has to be removed, and to that end you will have to donate some land to the Faquir.’ You little children are carriers of my message. Those who will convey this to their mother, will please raise hands.” (All the children raised their hands, some enthusiastic ones both the hands).

In the evening meeting, there were 9-10 thousand people. Vinoba sat on the rostrum with Ashadevi and commenced his speech:

“To-day is my third day in Pakistan. Many people have come and I see much enthusiasm on their faces. Why? Because they have learnt by now that a Faquir has come who asks for land for the poor. With whose strength am I continuing this journey? It is God’s. He dwells in all, even in little children. He is infinite but manifests even in tiny spots. On my request Kari Sahib, who is present here, recited a verse from the Holy Quran. It says, ‘God is the light of earth and heavens.’ A small lamp in a corner lights the whole house. In the same way, He dwells in a small heart but His light spreads everywhere. He shines everywhere. With this faith in God, I have come here. I went to Telangana 11½ years back. The Communists had become a terror there and the Govt. too tried to terrorise them. I walked to that place. In a meeting at a poverty stricken village, I asked the villagers as to what they were lacking in. They replied, ‘We have no opportunities for work. We need

land to earn our livelihood.' I was at a loss to understand where I shall get land from. By then big and small people from the village had collected. I made an appeal to the audience for land. A gentleman got up and offered land that was more than was demanded. It set me thinking, I could not sleep that day. I prayed for guidance and asked, 'What is the subtle indication in this event? Should I continue asking for land?' And a reply came from God within, 'Yes, go on doing that whether you get response or not.' And since then I have taken to this work. In Telangana I received 12 thousand acres within two months. But the problem stated to be here is that East Pakistan has not much of land. But I see land all round and the sky above—the same seen everywhere. I got Bhoodan even in the thickly populated State of Kerala, and as much as one acre from a poor man in Pakistan who had only 4 acres in all! One acre would mean much to the donatory, it will be a means of his livelihood. I once asked an old gentleman if he was feeling contentment in life. He replied in the affirmative saying that he had procured 5 acres of land for his children after putting in hard work throughout his life. Ten lac acres distributed to the poor in India means providing for livelihood to 1 million people. I have been on the land of Pakistan for the last three days. I shall feel happy if I breathe my last here. I have told my companions to cremate me here only. I have no desire that my ashes be taken to India. I have received only 6 'Dan-patras' but I shall be at peace even if death comes to me at this very moment. For, I have been provided with an opportunity to serve such a huge mass of people. I do not feel any difference between India and this country, the same earth, water, sky and man. All races in all the countries are creation of God. Wheresoever there is man, the child of God, there is manifestation of love and compassion. This is my belief.

The Virtue of Charity

All religions have ascribed a high value to charity. In the Quran it has been said in the very beginning 'Spend for the poor from what God has provided you with.' In Hinduism it has been ordained, 'Share justly and eat.' The Bible says, 'Love thy neighbour as thyself.' It has been said in the Quran that one of the characteristics of a true Muslim is that he will give in charity a part of his earnings. In Kerala the Christians told me that what I was preaching was Christianity; at Sarnath near Kashi the Buddhists said that I was talking Buddhism; the Sikhs in the Punjab said that the same thing was preached by Guru Nanak. Thus all the religions emphasise the same thing—to love all and help the poor.

I am confident that this country too will give abundantly in Bhoodan. But for that all of you must have zeal and perseverance. You have to carry the message to every home. I know very few of you personally; besides, I have limited time at my disposal. You, the sons of the soil should make efforts and they will be crowned with success.

Usury Prohibited

It is everybody's wish that his country may achieve greatness and power. But that will be possible only when the village becomes powerful. If the villagers are deprived of milk and butter and the cattle of their proper feed, how will the crops be raised? If the crop is not good, how will the country be strong? Therefore, there should be unity in every village—oneness in mind and heart, the feeling of belonging to the same family. All distinctions of caste, religion, language etc. will have to be removed. The various religious scriptures do not contradict each other. It is we who raise disputes and put the blame on the holy books.

Usury is prohibited in all religions, the Quran specifically

mentions that. But who follows that ? Today even the Govt. takes interest. This is sheer exploitation of the poor. The ownership of land should vest in the village as a whole ; every house should have some village-craft e.g. spinning wheel, and cloth should be manufactured in villages. Then only will there be production of wealth on a vast scale.

I go to bed at 7-30 P.M. and shall leave this place tomorrow at 4 A.M. So, now I request you to give in donation whatever is possible for you before I retire. The substance of my today's talk is that all should donate, all distinctions should vanish, usury should be stopped and every family should spin. Then only will people be happy and strong."

The meeting came to an end after the silent prayer. Baba kept sitting in meditation in one corner near the school pond for some time, and people glanced at him from a distance. As the minutes fled, people left one by one and Baba went to bed at 7-30 P.M. as is his wont.

●

IV

THE RIGHT OF OWNERSHIP HAS NO DIVINE SANCTION

The fourth day.

The journey for the day commenced at 4 A.M. Kalindi Bahin writes in her diary :

Someone was standing in the darkness of the night. The figure moved as Baba approached near ; the hand held a bottle of water. Crossing the way, he spoke, 'my child is ailing; it has not responded to any treatment whatsoever. Kindly recite some hymn and bless that the child gets recovered.' Baba caught him by the hand and said, 'You have faith in God, is it not ? Then be sure your child will regain health.' The man bowed and left. I am reminded of Lord Christ. People met him on the way and were cured of their diseases by his mere touch. God knows since when that person had been waiting. He might have heard that a Faquir from India had come and would pass that way.

We reached our destination at about 7 A.M. and camped in the compound of an old Zamindari house of Bhitari, the premises of the Village-welfare Club. About 400 people had collected there. Addressing them Baba said :

"Today I have come to a far interior village. In such a village there is an inner light. In bigger villages which are connected by railways and motor transport, the working of the intellect is more pronounced than the guiding light of the heart. It is the same in all countries. The very name of this village

is significant—Bhitarband i.e. a village in the interior. There should, therefore, be more inner light. I have been treading along on foot in India for the last eleven years and a half. Now the Govt. of Pakistan has kindly permitted me to pass through it. I have not come here with some specific purpose. My only work is to spread the message of love. It will bear fruit if that is the Divine will; my work is only to create an atmosphere. Once love begins to flow, various types of work could be started—some will donate land selflessly, ladies in every house will spin, people will put on Khadi manufactured in their own village; the people can also decide that they will not charge interest from each other etc. All sorts of good work could be possible with the dawn of love.

Since my first day in Pakistan I have been urging people to give land to the landless. Yesterday I was in a big village, many people had gathered but there was only one donation. This village is small and so I expect more. But I shall not insist on that. I have talked to you of three things and shall speak more afterwards. You too should say what you want to !”

It was ten o'clock in the morning. Baba went out and took his seat in the open. The ‘ mukhias ’ of the village came to meet him. Baba placed his point of view by saying, “ If the labourers get land, they will work with a feeling of gratitude on the land-holders’ lands. Bhoodan has commenced here, the gates have been flung wide, an opening has been made. It is now your duty to push on the work.” At 11 A.M. the officials and press-reporters who were accompanying Baba were introduced. Baba said to them, “ The beginning of donation should be made by you.” All began to laugh. An official said, “ We are refugees from India. Land we have none. But nobody believes that I am a refugee.” Baba intervened, “ Yes, that is right ; but if you are landless, you should be

prepared to receive land. Any donor here ?” The official was disarmed.

In the evening, the school teachers came. . Baba asked them a number of questions. In the end, a teacher requested Baba to recite from the Quran. Baba laughed and then gave recitations from the holy Book for about 5 minutes. They heard with rapt attention ; after that they said, “ We cannot speak the language of our great religious book. We are much pleased to hear it from your lips.” One of them asked, “Where is your home ?” Quick came the reply, “To which country does the Brahmaputra belong ? To Tibet, Assam or East Pakistan ?” “ You are a carrier of movement ”, someone remarked.

In the evening prayer-meeting, more than five thousand people had assembled. Addressing them he said, “ I have come here for a short duration, only 16 days. If we work well, we can bring about beautiful results by the grace of God. I am much impressed by the love and enthusiasm displayed by the people during the last four days. I find no difference between the people of this place and those of India. It is said that this part is short in land. But Kerala in India has a greater shortage. The countries like China, Japan etc. are still more short of land. As such, village industries should be started, besides agriculture. God has given land for all, however insufficient it may be. If someone claims ownership of land, he goes against God’s will. All religions say the same thing.

Keep the Labour Satisfied

We must increase production with the help of science. Japan’s per acre yield is four times that of India or Pakistan. To achieve that, the labourers will have to be kept satisfied. These days they neglect work. I have observed that when they go to the fields for work, they carry ‘ Hukka ’ in one hand

and a tool in the other. How can the man work then ? Besides, when the owner is away, he works less ; the owner too tries to make under-payment. Both try to cheat each other. This results in lower yields and the country's production goes down. The owner and the labourer are like a pair of bullocks. If they keep pace with each other, the cart will move smoothly. If the landless labourer gets some land in Bhoodan, his whole family will work hard on that land and he too will prove a willing worker on the owners' land. Throughout the world, owner-labour relationship is passing through severe strain, and it is this that is at the root of communism. If we do not want that, the labour will have to be kept contented. Communism cannot be stayed by show of force.

I thought of leaving the message of love—of Bhoodan—in this country too. I do not know of the result. The land does not increase with the rise in population and so the only alternative is to increase production and start village industries. But there is a limit to the efforts of the Government. All cannot be provided work in the large industries of the country. I have seen the Government's report in this connection. Only 2 lac 60 thousand persons out of the country's one crore labourers have been employed in these industries. If cottage industries are started, every house will produce some wealth and villages will be humming with life. How can the country be strong unless the village attains strength. The village children are deprived of milk and butter and are under-nourished. They eat only rice and that too is not always available. This is why the children are weak and the bullocks too, because they are ill-fed. Under such circumstances how can production increase ? How will the country be strong ? The city is the upper storey ; the village is the ground-floor and that must be strong. The Government alone cannot do that. If the villagers make a

joint effort and are provided Government aid from above, then it can be accomplished. The people's effort is milk and the Government help is a starter to turn it into curd. The starter will not produce curd out of water. The country is free and the people think that the Government must do every thing. The rain water is symbolic of God's grace, but we have to cultivate land and produce crop with our labour.

Create Capital in the Village Itself

Today capital is flowing to the cities, not to the villages. There is capital lying idle in the houses but its lustre is not reflected on the face of the village. That is why the villages are not villages in the right sense, but mere houses huddled together. True villages can take shape only if we create capital there and establish Gram-Sabhas. This will be possible when the landowners donate land to the poor land-less. Capital will be created by each family contributing a portion of the crop to the common pool ; this will then be utilized for village uplift work. Only then will a new village take shape. This is what Bhoodan aims at. The village will then be one family with love at its base. We are all one, we belong to one humanity. If we do not shed the distinctions of castes, religions, countries etc. the village will not become one family and it will not progress. That is why I have been asking for Bhoodan since my arrival here and have also received something every day. The rain of Bhoodan has commenced precipitating in drops. And the work will go on even though my sojourn here will be short. For, man has love and compassion innate in him. I have a robust faith in man's essential goodness and not in organizations, and as such the Bhoodan work will go on without them. Now we shall sit for a silent prayer for five minutes, after which please do not leave before giving Bhoodan." After the prayer, three Bhoodans were announced.

ONLY TWO PROBLEMS : HUNGER AND NUCLEAR ARMS

The fifth day.

The journey commenced today at 3-30 A.M. Some of the press-reporters were accompanying Baba on foot. The representative of the 'Statesman' made a comment, "I have not been able to follow the philosophy of your Bhoodan movement. I do not think the problem can be solved through it." Baba replied, "There is no philosophy in Bhoodan ; there is only love. All problems will be solved when love begins to flow." The discussions went on for some time when the gentleman put forth a suggestion, by saying, "Both India and Pakistan suffer due to floods in the Brahmaputra. Will it not be in the interests of both to work out a joint plan to fight out the menace ?" "Of course", replied Baba, "but for that there should be a Federation of the two countries. I want to extend this concept to the whole world and that is why I talk of World Federation, of Jai Jagat."

Kalindi Bahin writes in her diary : A well-decorated boat was waiting. We all got into it. A good distance was to be covered. It took us nearly an hour and a half; when we reached the other side of the river, a large crowd was seen waiting for Baba's arrival. One wonders how the news reaches them. They do not get newspapers, nor did our workers go to them. How then did they get the news ? It is the winds that carried this tidings on their wings, 'A Faquir from India has come, he talks of human oneness, of love. He wanders carrying the message of love to the people of the world.'

The substance of what Baba said while addressing them that morning and what he expressed during his speech in the evening prayer meeting is given below :

“Today is the fifth day of our journey through Pakistan. I am happy at your overwhelming love for me. But I want something more from you—land for the landless. I want Kudi (twenty) Bhoodans from Kudigram.

World's problems are increasing one by one. Several plans—3-year, 5-year—are being drawn out to solve them. But no right solution has been found out to meet the problem of hunger ; the woes of the poor are multiplying. This can be solved through Bhoodan. God has given us two hands to work and serve, but only one mouth. Were we bestowed with one hand and two mouths, the world would be in a terrible situation, for then we could have worked less and eaten more. If there is love and co-operation between two of us, then there will be four hands to work ($2+2=4$). But if there is opposition between the two, not a single hand will be able to work ($2-2=0$).

The burning problems of the world today are first, global hunger, and second, mounting number of nuclear arms. All-destructive bombs are being manufactured. Man is getting in his possession the power of science in a large measure. With it are multiplying man's wants and sensual desires. Population figure is going up and so also that of hungry mouths. The only remedy is to share the food with others. Till then, there will be no lasting peace in the world. I have adopted Bhoodan as a means of solving the problem of hunger.

The second problem is that of nuclear weapons. Efforts are being made to strike terror by one nation in another. Russia though advanced in war-fare, industry, commerce, agriculture,

fears U. S. A. On the other hand, inspite of its possession of the power of science in large measure, U.S.A. is afraid of Russia.

Thus mutual distrust and fear is casting its dark shadow on the whole of the earth and preparations for deadly weapons are going on. It cannot be forecast what will happen when. About 17 years have passed when atom bombs were dropped on Hiroshima in Japan. Lakhs of people were killed or disabled. The reactions of that tragedy are still visible. The expansionist tendency of Japan has been curbed after the catastrophe, but the problem remains unsolved. Nothing can be solved by force, by arms.

God has taught every human being to love. The world is so constituted that from his very infancy man learns of love—he learns love, mother-tongue and religion from the mother. It is the parents who teach the children to speak truth, to love, to keep peace. Reciting a verse from the Quran he said, 'Only those will cross who have faith in God, who work conscientiously, who speak and preach truth. The rest will be losers.' God has given man such a kind heart that man cannot endure the sight of suffering of even small creatures. But today, the same human being is overpowered with fear of his own race. We must shake off this fear, compose our differences, live in love."

After the usual evening prayer, four Bhoodans were declared. One of them amounted to 50 Bighas. This land was distributed among 10 persons. When the meeting was over and Baba was talking to some persons in private, a petty gram-vendor came and said, "I have no land, but I want to give something in donation." Thereafter he wrote a Sampattidan-patra of Rs. 5/- per month and handed it over to Baba.

Just when the sun had rolled down the horizon, a gentleman of huge physique came and threw himself at the feet

of Baba. He said, "I wish you would stay longer in this country. People here are devotional, they want to hear good things. I request you to extend your stay by a few days more."

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VI

FUNDAMENTALS OF BASIC DEMOCRACY: LOVE AND COMPASSION

The sixth day.

The next camp after Kudigram was Panga. It was a distance of 9 miles and so Baba set out on his journey at 3.30 A.M. After covering 6 miles Baba was received by the people of Panga at Kathalbadi from where he was taken by a circuitous route so as to enable women folk to have his Darshan. At 7-30 A.M. we reached Panga. The students and teachers of the High School there took prominent part in the reception. About a thousand people had assembled in the School compound. Addressing them Baba said :

The Age of Collectivity

“Today is my sixth day in East Pakistan. We got a good donation at Kudigram yesterday—60 Bighas in all. Those who give in Bhoodan shall decide the donatory too. Today it took much of my energy in reaching here and so you should reward me with more Bhoodan. Take into account the number of landless people in the village and all should donate land accordingly. This is an age of collectivity. All should work in a collective spirit. The people of the village should jointly solve their problems. Basic democracy is functioning here. The Union Council consists of 80 thousand members; they can themselves give in Bhoodan as well as participate in the Bhoodan movement. When the press-reporters had asked me if I would form some organization to carry on the work

of Bhoodan after my departure, I replied in the negative. But now I feel that the Union Council of Basic Democracy can take this work in hand. Those who do that will be held in esteem by the people. You will earn the affection and sympathy of the thousands by giving only some land in Bhoodan."

After rest and bath etc. some prominent persons of the village including school teachers came to Baba. A new idea was put forward to them by him. Referring to the Basic Democracy he said :

"I have partly gone through the present Constitution of Pakistan. Basic Democracy can be a good beginning if we look at it from the point of view of love and compassion and not power, and if you do some work through this medium. Where power trickles from above, jealousy is roused even though it may be a miniature democracy. Where scope is wide, the outlook gets broader and jealousy has less chance to raise its head. In a small sphere, there is narrowness, and the possibilities of jealousy, ill-will are greater. That is why Gram-Swarajya cannot be ushered in by mere decentralization of power or authority. You may cut a big stone into very small pieces, still it will remain a stone in its components, it cannot be turned into butter. Similarly with power; you cannot change its nature by creating small divisions of it. The basis of Gram-Swarajya should be love and compassion on which should stand this structure. There shall be a Gram-Sabha which will receive in contribution a fixed proportion of the villagers' crop and take up village uplift work with this contribution e.g. cottage industries, education, settling of small disputes in the village itself etc. If they get grant from above, well and good. If not, it won't bother them much. There will be amity in the village and the Union Council will have contributed something to the good of the people. They will

give land to the landless and subsequently the whole village will turn into a Gramdan. Gramdan ultimately amounts to surrender of all ownership right to the village community."

The whole day Baba was busy. The evening meeting was attended by more than ten thousand people. Women also were present. The meeting commenced with the presentation of an address in Sanskrit to Vinoba by the students and the teachers of the school.

After that, Vinoba addressing the audience said, "Now I shall be in Pakistan for ten days more. My acquaintance with you is new, but looking to the feelings of love on your face I feel as if we have known each other for long. I have been moving in the different parts of India for the last 11 years and a half and then I longed to meet you. For my love is not confined to one particular country alone. Pakistan and India have one heart with two bodies. I came across a poem in a Bengali text-book prescribed for the students here. It has been said in it, 'Humanity is above the notions of caste and country.' It pleased me to read it, for it echoed the feelings of my heart. That is why I cry, "Jai Jagat". I wish victory for all. In the last world war, countless millions were killed and wounded. On both sides were followers of Christ and both prayed to God for victory. Whose prayer should He grant? It was such a war that the victory of one side would mean defeat of the other. It was not a prayer out of devotion. How can devotion be manifested by men in rage fighting with other human beings? If ten children of a mother divided in two batches begin to fight, and then each group prays for victory to her, what will she say? She will first ask them to stop fighting. Gurudeo (Ravindranath Tagore) once said, "People cry 'Vande Mataram'—salutation to the Mother; but none speaks of salute to the brother." If

brothers fight amongst themselves and pray to God, He will say that they are insincere in their devotion. It has been said in the Quran that mere adherence to one's Faith will not do; one must follow it in life. The devotion will be true only if you speak truth, help the miserable. Prophet Mohammad has said, 'Those who do not do even small acts of mercy, but offer Namaz five times mechanically as a mere show, will not be considered by God as His true devotees'.

I was asked as to why I had come here, and whether my work had been completed. I replied that my work was that of love in India which does not recognise the distinctions of this country and that, of Hindus and Muslims. Whether you offer prayers by facing East or West, makes little difference. It is an outward thing. What matters is that which is within. We can deceive all but not God. That is why the Quran prescribes, 'Love all, make no distinctions.' You will lower yourself if you look with contempt at others' faith in your vanity and assert that yours is the best. Some keep beards, others do not; some burn the corpses, others bury them. These are all outer differences. The inner truth is one, that of love. I see the same love and the same humans here as in India. There are children in the houses of the poor as in those of the rich. The children of the poor afflicted with poverty have to help the parents in their work. Had it been God's will that these children need not study, why should He have made them like those of the rich? The flame of love is burning in all. If a proper approach is made, the land-owners will surely give in Bhoodan. The recipients shall cultivate that land, they will not be entitled to sell it nor can they mortgage it. The donors will help them also with seed, plough etc. Those who ask for land on behalf of the landless, must have faith in the innate generosity of the people and then they will receive from them what they ask for.

If they go with the negative thought that people may not donate land, then they will not get Bhoodan. If you approach people with this faith that love and compassion reside in the hearts of men, you will get land. Some friends had suggested that an advance party of 2-3 persons may be sent ahead for preparatory work. But I disapproved of the idea, because I have faith in the people of Pakistan."

After the prayer, two Bhoodans were declared. ●

VII.

BHOODAN WORK—UNION COUNCIL'S SPHERE

The seventh day

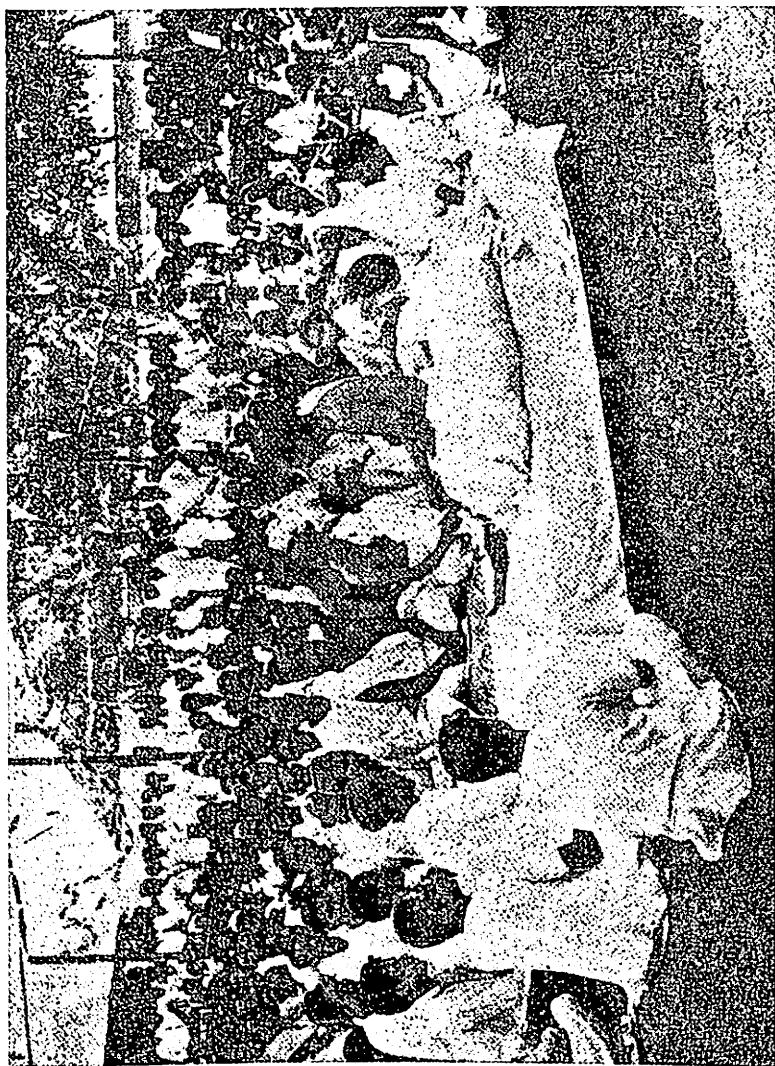
Vinoba goes to bed at 7.30 P.M. daily and gets up at 2 A.M. After attending to the daily call, Baba took his seat in a corner and read from the Bible. At the instance of Ashadevi, all members of the party sang 'Bhuvaneshwar ha.' The journey commenced at 3.30 A.M. and we reached our next camp, Tista High School at 7.30 A.M. About a thousand people were present. Addressing them Vinoba spoke :

"Today is the seventh day of my Pakistan tour. I am told that there is paucity of land here. If that is so, you may donate less, but everyone should donate. Those who have 4 Bighas may give half-a-Bigha, and apply the same amount of labour and manure to the rest of $3\frac{1}{2}$ Bighas. This would bring them the same yield which they used to get from 4 Bighas. The recipient of the half Bigha also will work hard and that will bring him some return. Thus, the total yield will increase. Please donate at least $1/20$ th of your holding."

When Baba had been free from bath etc., the Deputy Commissioner of Rangpur, Mr. Yaqoobali Khan, the Superintendent of Police Mr. Abdul Hai, the S. D. O. of Kudigram and other officers came to greet him wishing him long life, this being his 68th birthday. The Government of East Pakistan sent a telegram of felicitations expressing good wishes on his birth day.

Kalindi Bahin writes in her diary :

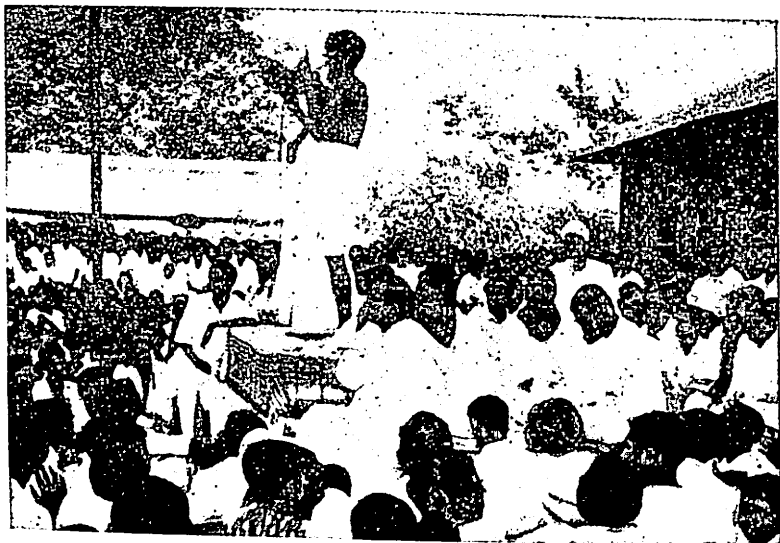
A gentleman came in with Charuda—tall, with white



At Tista, On Vinoba's birth-day- 11th Sept. 1962.



Addressing the students at the girl's school, Kudigram.



Speaking at the post-Prayer-meeting at Tista

beard and serene face. He was the medical practitioner of that place. He eagerly enquired, "When will I be able to see your 'Essence of Quran'?" Baba replied, "It is still in the press." The gentleman went on, "I am at the fag end of my life. I wish I could see that. I am very eager to have that." Baba replied, "The book is going to be published soon." "All right, I am giving you my address. Kindly arrange to send a copy to me. I suppose you have translated the holy Quran. Is it not?"

"No, not translation. It contains selections from the Quran, arranged subjectwise, e. g. What has been said about God has been compiled at one place, that about Prophets in another chapter and so on."

"I am eager to read that book. There is one more request: Kindly pray for my family."

Kalindi Bahin continues:

One sees lot of interest among people here for the 'Essence of Quran'. The representatives of the Press had asked questions about it at the very commencement of the journey. Baba smiled and said, "This book has received good publicity. I have not brought it with me. It is still under print. But newspapers are commenting on it even before its publication; in fact the proof of the pudding is in its eating."

A gentleman asked, "Has the Pakistan Government put a ban on the book in this country?"

Baba replied, "If it is anti-Islam, even Indian Government will ban it, as there are five crores of Muslims there. If not, it will be in demand in all countries. It has really received much publicity."

After 11 A.M. we all gathered around Baba in the school yard. A special prayer programme was planned for this occasion of his birth-day. The villagers, government officials

and press-reporters participated. After recitation of prayers, Baba addressed the gathering, "Any time is auspicious for reciting God's name. Today's is a special occasion for me. From the history of the world we learn that wherever there is man, he does good deeds as well as bad. All his vices are related to the body, and the virtues to the soul. The body perishes, the soul is ever-lasting. Therefore, one should forget man's vices and remember his virtues. All events, good and bad, are our creation. Everyone of us represents humanity. The more we create distinctions, the more humanity gets divided and the more human soul gets disfigured. All human beings are mine and I belong to all. It is a matter of pleasure that prayers from different religious scriptures and in various languages are sung. All religions, all languages are mine and I belong to all countries.

That I have been born in a particular country and shall die at a certain place is only a matter of chance. I am happy that I am in Pakistan today. This too is my country. Why, the whole world is mine and I belong to the whole world. People care more for me than what I do for them. That is why I feel indebted to society. Whether I do the Bhoodan work or any other, I do not think that thereby I oblige anybody. I am simply paying back the debt.

Today is Jinnah Sahib's death anniversary. So, you should give more in Bhoodan. Simply recalling his virtues will not do. You should undertake some selfless work like Bhoodan to commemorate this day."

The evening meeting was usually kept at 4 P.M. so that it might be over by 5 P.M. after which the Namaz would be offered. The Imam of the mosque nearby suggested that the time for the meeting be kept at 5 P.M., as the Namaz there was offered in those days just a few minutes before that.

Vinobaji readily agreed to the proposal. Today's was the biggest meeting ever held during Baba's visit in Pakistan. Twentyfive thousand people attended. He delivered a comparatively lengthy speech. He said, "Only nine days are at my disposal in this country. The audience is daily increasing in numbers. During the last $11\frac{1}{2}$ years I have walked more than thirty thousand miles in India. I shall continue God's work till the end of my life. This meeting is in no way smaller than the big ones I had addressed in India, nor is the enthusiasm here any the less. To see this strong surge of love for me is different from seeing it in action. Mere faith is not enough; it should manifest in action.

A good question has been asked today. I have been told that industrialization is necessary for the progress of the country. I have never objected to that. Population has considerably multiplied during the last fifteen years but industries have not grown proportionately either in India or in Pakistan. The problem is : What about the workless hungry ? What are we doing for them today ? Industrialisation will take, say, ten years. Shall we tell them to endure the pangs of hunger for ten years after which arrangements will have been made for them ? We should think of it here and now. If we take jaggery at this moment and it begins to taste sweet after our death, what is its use ? If I have to feed myself today and everyday, I must see whether there is some arrangement for others too. You give food to a hungry man today, but hunger will return to him after some time and you will have to feed him again. This will make him indolent and dehumanise him. So, he must be given instead means of livelihood. He should be allotted land on which his whole family may work for their bread. Bhoodan is valid for all the countries, especially for the con-

continent of Asia, which is short in land, where industries are insufficient and population is thick. Everything will be destroyed by adopting violent means to solve the problem of hunger. The path of love must be followed. Islam means peace, but how can peace descend on the hunger-stricken ? So hunger should be satisfied first; then we shall think of peace of mind. Islam says, 'First feed others and then eat'. All religions say the same thing. The essence of all religions is : 'Serve the afflicted and recite God's name'.

Basic democracy is good if good people are returned, otherwise the result will be bad. Now who should be considered good ? Is it those who are wealthy, or are educated, or are landlords ? No, it is they who are kind-hearted, generous, charitable; You should elect such people, otherwise you may have to repent.

The Impact of Love on the Dacoits

I shall narrate the story of the dacoits of the Chambal Valley. Only two years back I had been to that area. Dacoities have been taking place for the last fifty years there and are steadily increasing. The Government deputed special police to fight the menace. But how could peace be established when all the three sides carried guns viz. the police, the dacoits, the homeguards ? With faith in God I went there and met the dacoits. I said to them, "By what hideous methods you are collecting money ! Will you get peace by murders and dacoities ? Will it give you peace after death ?" This touched their heart. Twenty of them one by one surrendered themselves along with their arms. They had several costly and modern guns mounted with telescopes. The Government had announced that anyone who apprehended them would get an award of Rs. 5,000/- per dacoit. How

could such formidable dacoits surrender ? The light of love that had gone dim in their heart got brightened by the touch of love burning within me. They would exert their might during elections one way or the other and thus push up their influence. With their help some people have collected as much as a thousand rupees at a time; the politicians too have helped them and in return have received money. The police also got money from them. Do such people deserve to be elected ? There is a 'veil of learning' on the eyes of the sophisticated literate, somehow their heart gets darkened. That is why only the kind, the charitable and the humane should be elected. Then only will democracy flourish.

Prophet Mohammed was not literate. Once he was in deep meditation when the words of God appeared on a piece of paper. But the Prophet said, 'I do not know how to read'. Then the messenger of God came himself to convey His words. Subsequently the Prophet said, 'Were I literate, I would have to be satisfied with the writing only and would not be able to see God'. Thus mere literacy is not very important. While electing a member for the Union Council, do not be led away by the wealth a candidate possesses, look to his generosity, kindness and charitableness.

Bhoodan : Work of Basic Democracy

Our people suffer from inertia. It is their habit that they do not give in charity unless asked for or induced to do so. Hence the necessity of the persons who may go to people and induce them to give. People put question to me as to who will carry on the work of Bhoodan after my departure from here. My hope is that the members of Basic Democracy will continue that. If 80 thousand members of the Union Council take up this work, the Bhoodan movement will get a mighty

boost. I believe such is the Divine will. They themselves will donate; if the will to give and to collect donations is not there, how will they qualify for the membership? This is a work of love, service, compassion. This message of love I have carried far and wide in India and have brought here too."

As usual, silent prayer followed after the speech, and a Bhoodan of 17 Bighas was declared. Often has Baba expressed during the course of his talks, "If I get even one acre in Bhoodan, my purpose is served, for one acre provides means of livelihood to one man."

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VIII

ALLEVIATE HUMAN SUFFERING

The eighth day

The journey commenced at 3.30 A.M. All the local Muslims, teachers and students who had organised welcome to Baba the previous morning and had been present throughout the day, came to see him off at this late hour in the night—a moon-less night. It was pitch dark. We had to cross the Tista river on boat. The river flowed fast and had several large eddies near the railway bridge. It was a task to oar a boat there even during the day. Darkness ruled the sky. The light of the twinkling stars made a feeble attempt to reach the waters which mirrored a precarious image of the galaxy on the still surface. Baba was gazing up at the stars. He saw the Pole Star in the North, and the ever moving Time on his head. The bed of the river was not visible. Of course, we saw the boat taking a round or two in an eddy, and striking against a large pillar of the bridge once or twice. The clever boatman, however, rowed it to the opposite bank safely.

We were awaited there by a group of orchestral devotees holding musical instruments in their hands, their lips betraying an impatience for chanting the Lord's name. They bowed and asked Baba, "Can we start 'Kirtan'?" Baba assented. They began and continued recitations upto 6 A.M. when they were requested to walk silently. Baba took his morning milk. It may be mentioned here that his daily diet consists of two seers of milk which he takes in 4-5 instalments in the form of milk, curds or cheese; besides this, he takes 4 ounces of well-

boiled vegetables. We arrived at our camp, the Mirabag school, at 7 A. M. People had gathered on the road-side and in the school yard. On reaching there Baba addressed them, "Today is my eighth day in Pakistan. On the way several persons recited God's name. It was a happy experience. The recitation was of three names : Rama, Krishna and Hari. Rama gives delight, Krishna attracts us and in the end Hari takes away our life, gives peace. But these are only different names of the same God. Islam also speaks of One God. But His names are many. Man can recite His name according to his choice. But if all remember Him collectively, their hearts will unite. This is what will lead to peace. The Hindus utter the 'Hymn of Peace' every day. The very meaning of Islam is Peace. The Muslims wish each other with 'Assalaam Valekum' i.e. 'May peace grow in your life'. The response too is in the similar words. In Christianity they say, 'Grace be unto you and peace from God'. Every religion speaks of peace. Today Kennedy and Khrushchev talk of peace but in their hearts believe that peace is not possible without armaments. This problem of world peace is a major one. The second in importance is that of hunger. Hunger should be banished from earth and mind should be at peace. Only then atheism will fade away. In the last war, both sides were believers, belonged to the same faith—Christianity. If believers fight amongst themselves, atheism is bound to rise. If they live in love and amity, and help the distressed, there will be an end of atheism in this world. Who else will free the village people from their misery except the villagers themselves ? Shall we wait for the Govt. aid ? Suppose a child falls ill. Will his father send a telegram to the Health Minister to rush medical aid ? Will he sit silent waiting for that ? The village will have to arrange for his treatment.

I have got acquainted with one of the chairmen of the Union Council. In Pakistan there are eight thousand such chairmen from whom uplift work is expected. I request them to take up in their hands the work of Bhoodan. You have made fine arrangements for feeding me. But it will leave a bitter taste in my mouth if you do nothing for the poor. You will please sit together and discuss how much land can be given in donation." Today's camp had insufficient space, the roof as well the walls of the school were all of tin-sheets. In the noon, the house got as hot as the oven. It was a blazing sun outside. But this did not deter the people and they thronged in large numbers. A large tent was pitched in the school yard and they were asked to take seat there. By and by local people came and had interviews with Baba. He talked to them about Bhoodan.

The evening prayer-meeting commenced at 4 P. M. There was an attendance of about 5 thousand people. Speaking to them he said, "Today is my eighth day in Pakistan. It is very hot today. You have been sitting in the hot sun for a long time and so I shall not take much of your time. I had the good opportunity to study several religions. All of them, in essence, mean to relieve man from his pain. Man should fulfil himself through love and service. To sacrifice for others gives pleasure and should be easy to practise. The mother feeds her children first and then takes her food; she sometimes even goes without that. This she does out of love and hence does not feel the pang. If you ask a mother to give a report of the service rendered by her, she will be non-plussed. For she is not conscious of rendering any service. But if you ask an employee of some establishment to give a report, he will submit a 50 to 60 page account. It may perhaps include his photo too. And all this in spite of the fact that his work may

have extended to only a few days of the year. As against this, a mother cannot produce any report of her service, for she serves out of natural affection. In the Divine dispensation, love rules in every family. And so I always say, 'love resides in every house-hold, it must flow out'. Just imagine the delight of those who love and make sacrifice. If man remains unaffected with the pain and pleasure of others, in what way will he be different from the animal? It is a characteristic of man that he is not entirely lost in his own pains and pleasures. He relieves others of their pain and feels happy in the happiness of others. It is because of this that the saints and sages are held in high esteem by all, even by the thieves and dacoits.

During my padyatra, I have been talking of this religion of humanity. That is why I tell all land-owners to give some land in Bhoodan. All those who have donated land during the last 11½ years are ordinary people like you and me. Many of the donors here are Hindus and the recipients muslims; then there are Muslim donors and Harijan donatories. In this way, peoples' hearts will be united and all differences of caste and religion and of rich and poor will vanish. Those who undertake the work of unity are loved by all. Had I fostered differences and created dissensions among the people, would Pakistan Govt. have permitted me to come here? They thought, 'this man does not incite people to fight but tries to pacify them and works for amity'. So they permitted me to enter Pakistan. It has been said in the Quran, 'Spend for the poor from your earnings that God has granted you'. This has been ordained for all, not only for the rich. Look to those who are less fortunate than you and help them. Be like water—it flows to a lower level. Take out a bucket of water from the well and water from all sides

rushes to fill up the gap. There is an infallible urge for unity in its particles. So I say 'be like water', establish unity. I request all to give in Bhoodan." After the prayer, five Bhoodans were declared. ●

IX

PARENTS, TEACHERS AND LITTERATEURS

The ninth day

Baba set out on his march at 3.30 A.M. As the party moved further, people went on increasing in numbers. The next camp had been fixed at the residence of Jenab Masihurrahman, member of the Pakistan National Council who came to receive Baba at Mahiganj from Rangpur with chief citizens of that place. When we had reached a place half a mile away from our destination, it began to rain heavily. The people accompanying him ran helter-skelter, but Baba proceeded cheerfully in the pouring rain with such a speed that it was difficult to keep pace with him. We reached our camp at 7.30 A. M. completely drenched and the waiting crowd received him with a song composed by Ravindranath Tagore. Addressing them he said, "When it rains from above, I take it as showers of blessings from God. This is an age of science. It is time when all countries should be united and be one. Science has annihilated distance, but in our hearts we are far apart from one another. A stage has arrived when we must live in unity and love or we shall perish. Today our biggest problem is lack of universal love and peace. And so my slogan is 'Jai Jagat'." Kalindi Bahin records in her diary :

In the noon when we were having lunch, we were told that members of the local bar association had come. We got up to be present at their interview with Baba. The gist of the talk is given below :

Q. : There is paucity of land in E. Pakistan. Can you plead with the India Govt. to part with some of the land for the people of Pakistan ?

A. : It is a very good question. The same problem faces India. This can be solved through love alone. Whichever be the country, it shall have first to solve its internal problems with love. The land problem exists throughout Asia.

Q. : So you can plead with the India Govt. ?

A. : The thing cannot be done one-sided. There is lot of land in W. Pakistan, about six to seven times that of this place. The same problem will crop up there. So a solution will be possible only when there is a confederation of the two countries. Charity is one thing and action by Govt. another. With the solution of the question of World Federation will be solved the problems of all the nations. The 'Jai Jagat' will result in World Federation.

Q. : Is the communal problem confined to our two countries alone ?

A. : I don't think so. I don't see any such thing in the masses, either here or in India. But whenever a political question crops up, I find that the opportunity is exploited by raising the communal issue.

Q. : You spread the message of love. Were not the riots at Jabalpur, Aligarh, Assam against that spirit ?

A. : All this militates against my philosophy of life. Everywhere there is tension in the world. Public opinion has to be created and that is why I have been moving on foot, from place to place. The question is not what is happening in the world but how humanity will survive. In India 'Shanti Sena' has been organized.

Its members rush to the trouble spots whenever disturbances take place.

A short while after this interview, came the local litterateurs. In the course of his discussions with them he said, "You are all men of literature. In future the importance of your class is going to increase. All the great poets of the world have composed their poems in their own languages. They can express best in the very language in which they have been brought up, in the language of their parents and neighbours. This has been the usual rule. There can be an exception under special circumstances. Sri Aurobindo had gone to England in his childhood and so he forgot Bengali. He attained proficiency in English, French, Latin and Greek. He had to learn Bengali afresh after the return to his country. He also learnt Gujarati, Marathi, Tamil and Sanskrit. He learnt Sanskrit very well. But when he wrote on the Vedas the Upanishads and the Yoga-Sutra and composed his epic poem 'Savitri', he did so in English. This is an unusual event. But usually one writes in his own language. To rise above the surrounding atmosphere is the special characteristic of the litterateur.

In the Sanskrit language, the word poet means 'the seer' who looks far beyond. Whatever has been written by Ravindranath has been in the background of Bengal. His writings bear a deep influence of the East. Nature and literature are closely related. Ravindranath was in intimate contact with the Nature in East Bengal. Hence the influence of East on his poetry. All the same, his approach is universal. That is why his writings are popular throughout the world. More and more people will read them in future, for they are not limited by the narrow limits of time. Only those whose minds are not conditioned by time and place,

can really make contribution in the field of literature. Others may inspire the people of their time but the influence will not last longer. I don't mean to say that they have not to do anything for the age they are living in, they have to be aware of that need; but their inner vision will go to the far and beyond. Those who have high talents in this field, have a very subtle eye with which they can gauge the reactions going on in the minds of others. It is because they themselves are free from them. If they have a disturbed mind, they will not be able to take a dispassionate view. How can they then have a global vision? If you stand on the sea-shore or are on a voyage by steamer, then only you can have a full view of the sea. But if you yourself are below the water, how can you have the surface view? How will poetry be born? That is why the litterateur should keep himself detached. But mere detachment may lead to renunciation of the world, to liberation from the cycle of birth and death, but will not create literature. Again if they are possessed by passions they cannot do anything in this field; if they are free from passions and withdraw from the world, then also they will not turn litterateurs. Only those who embrace life and at the same time can remain detached, can create literature. If they are not detached while accepting the worldly life, the world will be too much with them, they will not be able to turn out any literary piece. Detachment and withdrawal from the world may liberate their soul, but cannot turn them into litterateurs. This is my understanding as to who can produce literature.

Language which conceives of Universal Man can be given high Place

Bengali is one of the great languages of the world, the mother-tongue of at least 8 crores of people. It occupies

a place among the 10-12 languages of the world, each of which is spoken by more than 5-7 crores of people. But the most spoken language alone is not necessarily the richest. The language in which the universal man has revealed himself can be termed well-developed. Bengali is such a language and so it is one of the great languages of the world. No doubt, it has not produced literature like the English language ; that will come out gradually. But the Bengali language has the humanistic bias in its literature. It is this thing that gives a high place to a language.

People ask me, 'Which of the world's languages will be read and learnt the most?' My reply is, 'That which will be instrumental in establishing world-peace'. I don't know which language will attain that merit. Horace Alexander from England had once come to see me. He asked me, 'By which country can world peace be established?' I replied, 'By this country, and England too'. He was pleased at this and enquired, 'Why did you name England?' I said, 'Because it withdrew from India and Pakistan'. It could have continued for some time more. This may have lead to conflicts, disputes, injustice. But the British people were wise, they saw the futility of continuing any further and so they abdicated. If they disarm, it will be a disarmament of the strong. Britain can do that. Our country can do it because it has had a tradition of peace and non-violence since the time of Lord Buddha. I told him that because of such reasons this work may possibly be accomplished by these two nations. But I did not say that the Germans would not do that. They too can do that because they have suffered much during the last two world-wars. But I cannot say who will actually do that. I however, believe that the language of the people who will establish peace will find favour with the whole world.

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LITTERATEUR : THE GUIDE OF SCIENCE

One thing more. Among the litterateurs, there exists a bond of brotherhood, irrespective of their nationality or whether their nations have been at war for long. The responsibility of carrying this mantle falls on them. Man will perish if he uses the destructive power that has come into his hands through nuclear weapons—neither literature will survive nor humanity. Who will guide this blind power of science? The litterateur. That is why a greater responsibility will devolve on him in future. The power of science is unenlightened. It will work the way it is directed. The gist of what I want to say is that only through the path of peace can the world be saved. But all have lost their mental balance today. Who will then bring peace? They who have the power of discrimination are the torch-bearers and can show the path to the world. If the litterateurs think dispassionately, they can have the competence to give guidance to science.”

The evening meeting commenced at 5 P. M. It was arranged near our camp, but the space was not ample, looking to the large crowd that had assembled, and so order could not be maintained. In his brief speech Baba said :

“The site selected for the meeting is not sufficiently spacious considering the number of people who have come. This is causing inconvenience to you and so I shall not take much of your time. Today is my ninth day in Pakistan. My work is to forge unity, to extend the area of love. Bhoodan is a good means to that end. The most formidable task before man today is freedom from fear. Nations suffer from a fear-complex. Whatever appears in their Press about another country is taken as true by them and much energy is being spent to generate fear, ill-will and suspicion in the world. Effort is

being made to mould people's minds in a particular pattern. The result of this Press-propaganda is that the minds of the children are poisoned against other nations. They forget that the people of other countries are not monsters but human beings who have love and compassion in their hearts. What a vicious circle of violence, ill-will and fear ! Who can check this trend ? Parents in houses, teachers in schools and litterateurs everywhere else. This three-fold power alone can save man. When the father asks the son if he goes to school in time, he tells a lie for fear lest he be punished for his irregularity. The father inculcated fear in the son while emphasising discipline. The child lost his innate fearlessness in the process. The result is that he will fear the police and government officials in later years. Real love is possible only in a state of fearlessness. So the work of world peace should begin in homes and schools. The child should be allowed freedom to think. I always say, 'Discard what I say if it does not appeal to you'. The children should be given the same training. But all the nations try to indoctrinate the students according to their concepts. There is no scope for free thinking anywhere. We have to pave way for that. So, the fundamental thing is to make the village self-dependent. Then only will the spirit of mutual love and help grow in the world. The future of world peace lies with the parents, the teachers and the litterateurs.

Now we shall sit for silent prayers for 5 minutes. I have remarked that we create divisions among ourselves in order to remember God. Can we not pray together ? Newspapers have commented that I propose to stop individual worship and want to propagate my own method. But I have never meant that. If some high-born says in his vanity that all cannot sit together to dine, then I must say that he is in the

wrong. Such an objection to a get-together on dinner is untenable. Collective dining has its own importance. But this does not mean that people shall give up eating in their homes. Similarly individuals can pray in private or in public. But does it debar anyone from praying with others jointly? Certainly not. This is all that I say. Let us now be quiet and pray in silence." After the prayer, Masihurrahman came and handed over a 'Danpatra' of 10 Bigahs of his land to Baba. A Gujerati lady requested for a garland by way of a token of his blessings to her. Baba said, "Take a vow in the name of God that you will not tell a lie." She agreed and Baba put a garland on her neck. She bowed and departed.

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FUNDAMENTALS OF AN ISLAMIC NATION

The tenth day

We set out for our next halt, Paglapir at 3 A. M. On the way the well-known Ayurvedic Physician Yashoda Babu got engaged in discussions with Baba. He said, "The Indian Government has made a plan for birth-control; the same is being done by the Govt. here. Will it not be better to adopt the four-staged programme of life as envisaged by the ancient Rishis wherein celibacy was emphasised? That would not only lead to birth-control but would also help in the cultural advancement of the people." Vinoba replied, "Of course that would be good. Man at 50 and woman at 40 or 45 should live as companions, not as husband and wife." After a little pause Yashoda Babu put another question, "In a free country like India, should not the government be run with the advice of the sages as was done in the days of yore?" Vinoba answered, "Those were the days when it was the reign of Kings, and the sages and advisers were maintained on state coffers. Now it is the age of democracy and there is parliamentary system of government. So it cannot be run with the help of the sages as in ancient times."

Question : What is your view about compulsory teaching of the Vedas, the Upanishads, the Gita etc. in the universities in India ?

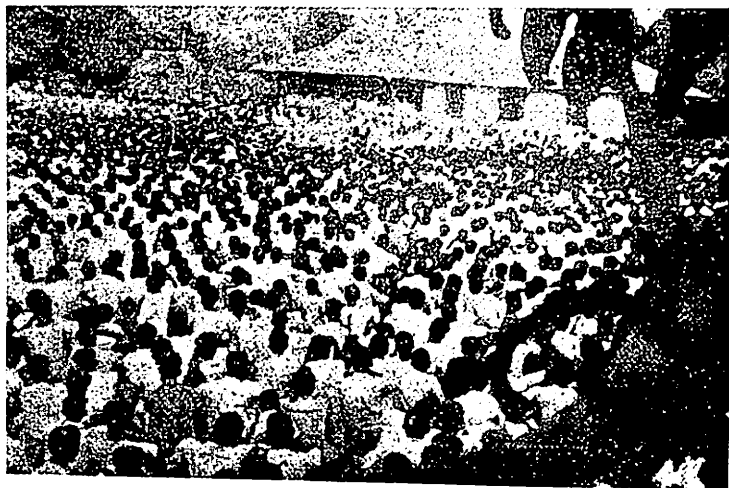
Answer : Study of religious scriptures is optional in some universities there, but it is not advisable to make it compulsory. There should be facilities for the study of scriptures of all religions.

We arrived at the Paglapir dak-bungalow at 6.35 A. M.



On the way to Rangpur.





A large crowd assembled to hear him at Paglapir



www.vinoba Speaking at Gopalpur

Addressing the people who had assembled there, Vinoba said, "I liked the words of greetings from the little children. Scouting fosters unity and love among them. The flame of love should burn in every village. I am much pleased to come here and have your affection. I want land for the landless. This is a small village, but a small village has usually a generous heart. In the city, the sophisticated and the rich live, but they are not large-hearted. During the last few days I have daily been favoured with some Bhoodan, but I want that every land-holder should donate some land. You will please accompany our workers to every house in the village and collect Bhoodan for the poor. Teach this song to the children, 'None shall be without land, none, none' and donate whatever you can, each one of you. If you can accomplish that, this village will rise in people's estimation and will lead others. Suppose you have five members in your family who claim your care and also share in your property. Treat me as a sixth member and part with 1/6th of what you possess, for me i.e. for the poor of your village. If everybody shares some of his land with the landless, by the evening the children will learn the song, 'None is left landless now, none, none.'

In the after-noon a group of young men from Raipur came to discuss certain points with Baba. A teacher of Raipur college, some press reporters and litterateurs were among them. The gist of their discussions is given below :

Q. You have spoken good of our Basic Democracy. Will you like it to be introduced in India too ?

A. I have not eulogised it in the sense you mean. I have tried to drive home the fact that it is a good beginning. If the Union Councils take up village development work in a spirit of love and compassion, then they will promote real democracy. You have noticed that in a

period of emergency, Democracy does not believe in itself. This is mainly because the country's power of governance depends on the power of the military. So long as Democracy is not rooted in non-violence, it will not be a true democracy. So whenever I have referred to Basic Democracy, I have done so with the idea that good work is possible at the grass-roots.

Q. Can Basic Democracy bring about real emancipation ?

A. Emancipation cannot be attained so long as violence is at the base of democracy. We are today living in a strange world. The great national leaders of the world have lost faith in violence, but have not developed faith in non-violence. They are in a fix, uncertain. In this situation, the litterateurs are a source of my hope. The teachers have no faith in the power that lies in the field of education, for changing the society.

Q. The communists say that theirs is the path that will lead to world peace. What do you think ?

A. Compassion is the motive power of communism. Though it takes recourse to violence, it aims at wiping out the misery of the distressed. We too should have such strong feelings. The ideal should be the synthesis of revolution and non-violence. Generally it is observed that those who are committed to non-violence acquiesce in the status quo, while those who want to bring revolution are given to violence. To speak in the language of the Marxian dialectic, Non-violence+Status quo is Thesis; Violence+Revolution is Antithesis, and Non-violence+Revolution is Synthesis.

Q. What should be done to usher in the non-violent revolution ?

4. First, decentralisation of power—maximum power at the primary level, minimum at the top level, and only moral power at the top-most.

Second, formation of a cooperative community.

Third, full opportunities for overall growth of every individual.

Fourth, the spirit of sacrifice for social welfare.

Fifth, knowledge and work should proceed in tandem in the field of education. Today, those who do manual labour are uneducated and those who have education, do not do manual work. In this way, there have risen two categories in society, the labour and the intelligentsia.

I have dwelt on it extensively in my book 'Swarajya Shastra.' The base of non-violent society will be gramdan, i. e. whole village as one family. Bhoodan will create a favourable climate for that.

In the end Vinoba said, "Three powers work in this world—Sattwa, Raja and Tama. I don't discourage any. Even 'Raja' and 'Tama' shall stay, but under the control and direction of 'Sattwa.' If there is no 'tama', we shall not get sleep. In absence of 'raja' we shall not be able to work, and if there is no 'sattwa,' we shall not have pure intelligence. Sattwa will serve as the rails, 'raja' as engine and 'tama' as carriages. 'Raja' and 'tama' are without intellect. Of the dreadful state through which the world is passing, I take the view that it is the last sparkle of the dying embers." The evening prayer meeting commenced at 5 P. M. About 10 thousand people had collected. Addressing them Vinoba spoke :

"This is my tenth day in Pakistan. Yesterday at Rangpur a friend came and asked me to give blessings that they might be fearless. It was a good wish. Fearlessness is a great quality. But how to develop it? Those who are too much

identified with the body, cannot turn fearless. But if one thinks that he is more than mere flesh and bone, that he is soul which is present in all the bodies, then he can shed fear. Such a man neither fears anybody nor makes anyone afraid of him. The same is true of a free man. It is characteristic of him that he neither submits to anyone nor keeps anybody in submission. Fearlessness should be there, but one who causes fear in others cannot be termed as fearless and one who keeps others in bondage cannot be called free. During the first worldwar when the Germans went on conquering small countries one after the other, people thought that Germany was very courageous and powerful. But when they encountered U. S. A., they surrendered. This defeat or victory in war is dependent on physical force; there is no question of bravery or courage in that. But even if a little child stands against a big power with his soul-force, then he will be considered fearless. You should understand that you are not confined to this body. 'I am in all the bodies'—when you realise this truth, only then you will be really fearless and can claim to have real love. When the light of this love spreads, there will be no enemy to you, on the contrary all will be your friends. People ask me some times, 'Is Bhoodan a complete programme? Or is it only a means to an end?' My reply to them is, 'My real object is to extend the area of love to the whole world. People of all countries are brothers, there is no difference in them. Bhoodan is only an indication of the village's 'one family' spirit. The landless poor have to be freed from poverty by donating land. If you ask whether Bhoodan will solve the problem of poverty, I shall say that much more will have to be done. But Bhoodan is a sine-qua-non of any attempt at liquidation of poverty, or of inculcation of the spirit of oneness and love. I am sure

Pakistan will adopt this programme. Islam means peace. 'All be at peace, fear and violence be replaced with love'—this is Islam. To impose one's views by threats or temptations will not work. Islam advocates against use of force in the matter of religion. It commends the path of love, politeness and understanding. Where a nation has taken shape in the name of such a religion, Bhoodan work will have to be taken up as indicative of the national ideal. Only God is the owner of land, none else. We cannot claim ownership over our own children even. We have been wrongly led into the belief that the responsibility of the child is exclusively of the parents. The village also has a claim on the child. It is not exclusively mine, it is village's too. If I serve the village and give thought to its problems, the community too will feel responsible for my child. I shall then have no cause for any anxiety, for the village will take care of it in case I die. All the children will be the care of the village ; it will make arrangements for their education ; the whole village will turn into one family and all will progress. Society so constituted will be called the Sarvodaya Community. Bhoodan is its beginning ; its object is the progress of all, victory for all. Real progress is that which is a progress for all. Real victory is that which is victory for all. That is why my slogan is 'Jai Jagat'—'The one world at one end and the village family at the other.' After the prayer, some Bhoodans were declared. A young film-actor came from Dacca. He belonged to Dinajpur district and came to offer 3 acres of land in memory of and as a token of respect for Vinoba's impending visit to that district. He wrote the danpatra, took some snaps and departed. There is no dearth of good-will in this world. Strange are the ways of God, none knows when and in whom he reveals Himself.

XI

COERCION VS. NON-VIOLENCE

The eleventh day

As on the previous day, our journey began at 3 A. M.

A friend from Brahmanbadia asked a question on the way.

Q. Is it possible to observe celibacy if you are on a non-vegetarian diet ?

A. There are several categories of food. The best is fruits, roots etc. It does not need cooking. Next is grain and vegetables which have to be cooked—by grain I mean rice, pulse, wheat etc. Next to this is grain, vegetables, milk and milk products. Milk comes in the third category because it has an animal origin. All the same it should be classed as vegetarian food. In the fourth category are fish, meat, with grain and vegetables, which is generally considered non-vegetarian. These are the four categories in their order of merit. Now which type will be congenial and to what extent, to observance of celibacy depends on the mental attitude of the person about the question. Taking that into consideration, he shall decide the type and quality of food that will be helpful to him. If you have greed for food, no type will be conducive, whether vegetarian or non-vegetarian. Non-attachment regarding food is alone of primary importance.

Today about a thousand or fifteen hundred people were accompanying us on the way—the biggest crowd so far. We reached our destination, the school at Taraganj, at about 7.30 A. M. Addressing the local people and those who had walked to this place with us, Baba said, “I have marked a

continuous flow of enthusiasm and love among the people during the last ten days. But this has to be canalised into useful ways. If steam escapes in the air, it will get lost. But if it is applied to the engine, tremendous energy will be generated. In the same way the flow of your love should result in some concrete work of service. Wipe out the tears of the poor landless by donating land for them. This will increase the scope of love and gradually the whole village will turn into one family and in the process will get strong and happy. The initiative and cooperation of members and chairmen of the Union Council will be very helpful. Ultimately the donors too will not be losers. A happy community life will take birth."

It will not be out of place to take note of the gentleman who played host to Vinoba's party at Taraganj. His name is Jenab Aminuddin Sarkar. When I had first come here in connection with fixing of Vinoba's programme and camps in Pakistan, I happened to meet him. He is associated with various progressive activities of the village. I talked to him about my intention of making Taraganj a camping place. He surprised us by stating, "I have heard about Acharya Vinoba Bhave and have also read something. It is our good fortune that such a great leader is coming here. I take the responsibility of making all arrangements for his party." It is unusual that a Muslim gentleman residing in a village in the far interior knows about Vinobaji, and this too has seldom happened that such a man, of his own initiative, offers to take all responsibility of making arrangements for the party. I introduced this host to Baba and narrated all about him. It had rained for a short while after the morning speech, but after some time, the sun shone bright. I entered Baba's room. He was talking to some of the workers on the need of making literature available to the people. He had noticed signs of thirst

for knowledge in the people. He exhorted the workers to go out on foot from village to village and quench this thirst by providing suitable literature to them.

The evening meeting commenced at 4 P.M. Ten thousand people thronged there. There was a little disorder but when Baba got up to address them, all was quiet. He said, " Do you see how orderly you have yourself become ? In the same way if you are self-disciplined in all walks of life without the need of any punitive measures, how fine it would be ! That is the road to real peace, where you can arrive through non-violence, not punishment. When people do not willingly follow the laws and rules, the need for punishment arises. (Pointing to the few persons who had still not taken their seats) Please sit down. You might have heard the story of the battle of Plassey. In spite of the fact that our soldiers out-numbered those of Clive, we were defeated. It happened because we lacked in discipline. In spite of successive victories, Napoleon got defeated at Waterloo and was sent to the island of St. Helena. When asked as to why so invincible a man like him lost the battle, he replied, " the marshal had been late by seven minutes to reach me with re-inforcements." You will realize the importance of discipline and punctuality from these examples. (All had taken their seat and got quiet after that.) I am glad to see that all are quiet now. If you adopt the same method of self-control in your social life, there will be no need of the police, and love will rule. The more the need of the police and the army the more will the society lose its freedom. Where the teachers dominate more than the police and all the boys and girls get educated, real freedom will dawn.

Suppose, a man goaded by want commits theft. He is handed over to the Police ; then he is produced before the magistrate who sentences him to, say, three years' imprison-

ment. Will this bring down the number of thefts ? Just imagine, who was really punished ? That person was the only wage-earner of his family. He committed theft for he could not make both ends meet. When in jail, he gets three meals a day and rest after evening. Every fifteenth day his weight is noted ; if some one loses in weight, he is kept on medical diet. Facilities for treatment are provided to the sick. Now look to the other picture—the condition of his wife and children. They began to starve as there was now no wage-earner in the family. Gradually the children and their mother too began to steal small articles and on being caught were insulted and beaten. Now you can see who actually suffered for the theft. During the country's independence struggle, I had been in the prison for 5-6 years. A prisoner was released after completing his sentence of fifteen years. Outside the jail there was none whom he could call his own. Tears came in the eyes of some of the co-prisoners at the time of his departure. Then he remarked, ' Where shall I go ? I have no home and so by next Sunday I shall return here.' He committed theft again and was brought to the jail next Sunday. Had I been a magistrate and also could make laws, I would have provided him with 3 acres of Bhoodan instead of sentencing him to 3 years' imprisonment and issued orders to him to work on that land in order to earn livelihood for his family. People will laugh at me for talking like that saying, ' who will hear this mad faquir ? ' But what I mean to say is that the Police cannot protect the society. Only the teachers, litterateurs and social workers can do that. When the society will be under their influence, when they conduct their own affairs i. e. when rule of love will prevail instead of rule of law, when children's education becomes the responsibility of the society, when other spheres of social life too become its concern, when

the village turns into one family, then will the reign of God dawn on earth.

So long as hunger haunts the villages, peace and self-rule will remain a mere chimera. When Bhoodan unites the hearts of all, and planning is done at the village level and in the village, the country will make progress. We can then also employ science to the service of the village for increasing production. I am not irrevocably committed to Bhoodan. I would like to be told of any other method that can bring love and peace to the villages. Suggestion from anyone is welcome. Now we shall sit in silence for prayer."

After the meeting three Bhoodans were declared.

XII

SURRENDER TO GOD'S WILL

The twelfth day

Starting at 3.30 A. M., we had reached our next camp Saiyadpur before the sun rose high. We were extended welcome on the way by several Marwari businessmen of Saiyadpur. Baba discussed with them on the subject of Sampattidan for propagation of suitable literature among the people. About two thousand people had assembled at the dak-bungalow. Addressing them Vinobaji said, "Today is my twelfth day in Pakistan. Several people entertained doubts as to the possibility of getting land in Bhoodan here, but I had faith. For, just as there are landless people, so also there are people with land-holdings who have hearts. On the very first day a Muslim donated one acre out of his four and since then I have been getting Bhoodan. For a piece of land people quarrel, go to courts and even murders take place. I am asking for land, to which they are so much attached, for the poor, and people have come to donate—A sight that attracts angels from heaven ! If this wind of love continues to blow in the villages, what strength it will infuse in them ! Please donate land as much as is possible for you. I am only instrumental in bringing together the donor and the donatory." Saiyadpur is a big business centre with a population of about 60-62 thousand. Elaborate arrangements were made for the occasion.

At about 10 A.M. a group of prominent Hindus and Muslims came and had long discussions with Vinoba on various subjects. They understood Hindi-Urdu well and so no interpreter was required. A gentleman asked the question,

“ You have studied all religions. Can you say which is the best ?” Baba replied, “ I take the essence of all religions, only what is good in them, just like honey-bees which collect honey from various flowers.”

Q. If so, do you intend to start a new religion then ?

A. No, these days it has been the tendency in many to assume that their religion and religious scriptures alone are the best. I do not approve of it nor do I believe in that. I take from all religions what is good for me ; this does not mean that the rest of the things in them are useless, but only that they have no use for me. I do not think in terms of superiority or inferiority of one religion to another.

Another gentleman then put a question : “ You talk of love, then why do you not make efforts to solve the Kashmir problem ?” Vinoba laughed and replied, “ This is a political question. I have not come here to discuss politics. If I have to do that, I shall approach President Ayub Khan and discuss with him rather than with friends like you.” This evoked laughter among those present.

Q. Marxism and Communism are making rapid strides in the world. How can that be stopped ?

A. Marx was a German ; but the appeal of Marxism is international, because, communism has undertaken to lift up the poor from misery which pervades throughout the world. The marxists are non-believers, but they lay great stress on doing away with all artificial distinctions and divisions. Their revolt against religions has its origin in the fact that the believers fight amongst themselves and exploit the poor rather than help them. The only remedy to put an end to Communism and atheism

is that the believers should stop quarreling and be ready to relieve the poor from their misery."

In the afternoon it was still hot. The tin shed was emitting heat like an oven. So Baba made a brief speech in the evening meeting which commenced at 4 P. M. He said, "Problems are cropping up in increasing numbers in this world and remain unsolved. Great men have come, done their utmost and gone, but the problems persist. So, I do not labour under any false pride that I take the responsibility of the solution of a certain problem. I shall be satisfied with whatever little I can do to serve. The rest will depend on God's will. By now 150 Bighas of land has been collected in Pakistan. Looking to the average of Rangpur district, this will be just sufficient for 100 persons to earn livelihood on. This is not a small achievement and I feel satisfied. I have no idea of starting an organisation here for this work. If it is the God's will that work should go on, some one will become His instrument. God has been generous to me compared to the labour I have put in or pains that I have taken in my life. If God inspires the eighty thousand members of Basic Democracy, a good work can be turned out. In India there is no organisation to take up this work, and still much has been achieved. Here we have a huge organisation of 80 thousand members and better results can be expected. Many of you have been standing in hot sun for a long time and so I shall not prolong my speech. Let us now sit for silent prayer for 5 minutes."

We got four Bhoodans in Saiyadpur. After the meeting, the S. D. O. Rangpur came to see Baba. Baba

asked him if there was any difficulty being experienced with regard to the registration of Dan-Patras of land donated by persons of Indian nationality. The S. D. O. assured that there was no difficulty and that there were rules and regulations under which that could be done.

XIII

WANT AND AFFLUENCE, ONLY TEST OF GOD

The thirteenth day

We arrived in the compound of the Alokdihi High School, our today's camp, at 6-30 A.M. Nature was beautiful here. The road-side Mahua trees were as if silently inviting the people to take rest under their shade; close by, a narrow river flows. A large field extends to the front and back of the school. About 5-6 hundred people had assembled with early hours of the morning, in the school compound. Addressing them Baba said, "Love is difficult to express from without—it will be a feeble attempt to do so by tongue or hand. Still one feels impatient to express it. I have found a way to do that. The love that we hold in our hearts should find a concrete expression. It reveals itself through donating bits of land to the poor in villages. I urge upon you to do that. This will add to mutual love. Gather together and decide as to who will donate how much; the donor will choose the recipient and hand over the possession of land to him. If there is crop standing, the donatory will cultivate it after the harvest. You shall also give seed to him in the first year. This way, village will get strong with the strengthening of the bond of love. If there is bickering and friction among the people, the village is weakened." After the break-fast when I entered Baba's room, I saw Baba studying the palms of Jharna and Kalpana and comparing them with his own. I was surprised and made the remark, "If you know palmistry, Baba, we can start a good business. Money will flow in. One thousand per palm! Then there will be ample funds for the distribution of our literature." Baba laughed heartily and said, "Palmistry is a flourishing business in U. S.A." I rejoined, "Whether one knows palm-reading

or not, one can make some money by pretending to know and making some forecasts." All laughed heartily. Then Baba spoke, "These sisters have strong hands, mine have gone tender. Both of the sisters are strong and can work hard." At 10 A.M. Vinoba had discussions with the East Pakistan workers. He said, "Achyut Deshpande has written an article in Bhoodan papers on my 'The Essence of Quran.' Vishwaranjan refers to an extract in it about 'hell-heaven.' His question is : Are hell and heaven really in existence where one has to go after death according to one's actions in this life ? Or is it a mere imaginary thing in order to tempt or instil fear for keeping up ethical discipline ? Or is it that the conditions of hell and heaven exist here only and all else is mere imagination ?

There is no doubt that on this earth too, there are situations of hell and heaven. It is observed that several persons live a comfortable life even after walking on a wrong path and doing unworthy acts while the righteous live in misery. Some say that the result of good or bad actions may not appear now, but one does get it some time in this very life. Others say that one is sure to reap the fruit in the other world whether one gets it here or not. Christ was crucified even though he tread on the right path, but even after hundreds of years, he lives in the hearts of millions.

To illustrate the law of causation, the inevitability of getting one's reward or retribution of one's own action, the Hindu, Bauddha, Jain and Islam religions have put forward the concept of the heaven and the hell. I have not read various descriptions given by different religions. Hindus, Jains, Bauddhas, Vaidikas, Vaishnavas, Shaivas, Gnostics and agnostics, all of them believe in re-birth. They believe that the work begun in this life, if incomplete, is to be completed

by taking another birth or births. A soul according to them is liberated from the bondage of the flesh only after fulfilling the mission assigned to it in its terrestrial existence.

In our dream state, we slip into conditions of suffering or happiness. Our reactions to outer impacts in waking state project to the dream state as experiences of pain or pleasure; the circumstances created there are unreal but pain and pleasure are real. Similarly hell and heaven are states of consciousness after death, irrespective of whether there are actually planes of hell and heaven or not as described in various scriptures.

Good actions leave healthy, soothing influence on our mind while bad actions leave corroding effects. When one commits a sin, he passes through an unpleasant experience before and in the very act of doing ; when one does a good action, the nature of experience is pleasant. In the next birth the latter is born with good tendencies and the former with ugly leanings. One who has attained a state free from all reactions will be re-born as one capable of keeping equanimity and thus after two or three births he will be free from the cycle of birth and death. Life of healthy influences, bad influences and of equanimity—these are the three modes of life. Heaven, hell and Brahmaloak are the three worlds or states of consciousness.

It has been said in the Quran that one tola of good action yields ten times return, while one tola of sin produces only a tola of its fruit. How gracious is God !”

After the discussions with the workers, a meeting with prominent persons of the village took place. This was attended by the S. D. O., the C.O., the manager of the E. P. Rly. and some members of the Union Council. Addressing them Vinoba said, “I go to the people with full faith and

confidence. If you want to touch a man's heart, you should do that through what is good in him ; if an attempt is made by emphasising on his defects, you will meet with failure. The twenty notorious dacoits of the chambal valley surrendered at my instance because I had faith in their goodness which is there in every man inspite of his innumerable defects. The response in love and land that I am receiving from the people is because I carry in me a feeling of love for them and have faith in their love. I go to them with a child-like faith and ask for land. That is why there is response. Basic Democracy is a good beginning in the context of the military rule that preceded it. If this institution works for the village uplift, the ABC of democracy will begin, it will help in establishing real democracy ultimately." After his speech, a chairman of the Union Council rose and said, "I don't find myself competent to shoulder the responsibility of such a work but I offer one acre of land in Bhoodan." Baba lovingly caught him by the hand and congratulated him for this offer. The group then left the place. After that, the manager of the E. P. Rly. asked Baba, "How will war end and peace dawn on this earth ? What is the object of your Pad-yatra ?" Discussions followed and he departed a convinced man.

The evening meeting commenced at 4 P. M. It had just rained, the ground was wet ; but people sat there inspite of that, to hear the saint. About ten thousand people had mustered in this small village. Baba spoke, "Today is my 13th day in Pakistan. It pleases me to see you all here. By the grace of God it has ceased raining now. There are poor and rich sections in the society. Why so ? The Quran says, 'To test.' Like question papers in school examinations, God too has taken out two papers—one for the rich, another for the poor. In the latter it has been stated 'You are passing through

several kinds of misery, still you shall speak truth, not lie; you shall not steal, be fearless, not feel helpless, shall not drink or take intoxicating things, and remember God.' In the paper of the rich it has been stated, 'I have made you rich, but do you have love for the poor? And while providing relief are you careful that you do not deceive others, do not become vain, and remember God? If so, you are declared successful. On the contrary, if you indulge in sensual pleasures, do not help the miserable, take intoxicating articles, deceive others, only amass wealth, adulterate the articles of food and other things, sell spurious drugs, then you fail in the test.' In this way, God tests both the poor and the rich. The Quran prescribes, 'Share your earnings with the poor.' I repeat the same thing every where. If you have love for the poor, you shall not charge interest on what you lend them. To feed the hungry will not solve the problem of hunger, for they will get hungry again. Besides, feeding in this way will demoralise them, make them indolent. But if you give them land instead, they will cultivate it and grow crop on it.

Wherever I go, I generally emphasise on the following things :

- (1) God alone is the owner of land, none else,
- (2) To charge interest must be stopped,
- (3) Abstain from drink or other intoxicating things,
- (4) Pray to God collectively with people of other religious faiths, besides praying in the traditional way.

If at any time, there is a real union of hearts in this world, it will be through God-consciousness among them. Hence the need of silent prayers."

After the silent prayer, a declaration was made about Bhoodan donated that day.

XIV

FROM GRAM-SWARAJYA TO WORLD STATE

The fourteenth day

The journey began at 3.30 A.M. As soon as we had crossed the Atarai river, an old lady was seen standing in the darkness of the night with a lantern in one hand and a glass of water in another. She bowed and requested Baba for 'Charanamrit' (washings of feet). When this was disapproved, she asked for another favour, "Baba, here is a Shiva Temple. Have a Darshan if you like." When asked how far it was, she said pointing her hand in one direction, "Just there." It was a minute's walk ; Baba followed the old lady who was walking ahead holding the lantern. He stopped a while in front of the temple, looked at the idol, bowed with folded hands and returned. Referring to it afterwards, he said, "I see God everywhere and the question of going for darshan to a particular place is irrelevant for me. But had I not acceded to the wishes of the old lady as a special case in this country, it would have marred the sanctity of the temple and also hurt the lady's feelings." Soon after that we found ourselves on a pucca road. Villages were a few and far apart. He remarked "There is plenty of land in Dinajpur." I informed him that most of it has been taken over in Govt.'s possession for a Govt. farm. Baba asked, "How much Bhoodan do you expect?" I replied, "Vishwabhai is in a better position to say that." Baba laughed, soon became grim and said, "From Gram-Swarajya to World State—the World State must come into being." Then he proceeded further slowly muttering, "What will be the shape of the World State?" We reached Khushhalpur Primary school at 7.30 A. M. which was to be our camp today.

There was plenty of open space with beautiful natural scenery. A little away there was a colony of Santhals. The school premises were donated by a Santhal and the building too was erected by the Santhals themselves for the education of their children.

About 4 to 5 hundred people had assembled. Addressing them Baba said, "To-day I have crossed a longer distance and am a bit tired. But as soon as I have your darshan, the fatigue disappears. This has been my usual experience. The world today is craving for oneness. This is the demand of the age. There are several articles of our daily use e. g. spectacles, pen, watch etc. which are manufactured outside with the help of scientific knowledge. One day we shall have to make them here. But there are many articles which we export and others which we import. Such interchange is bringing the world closer. The greater the scientific progress, the more forcefully comes the message from science that the world will have to unite. The earth remains no more unexplored, separated by distance. It is getting small. So a World State must come into existence. We shall have to make our hearts wide open. Man has grown intellectually in this age of science, but not so in the region of heart. There is a perpetual conflict going on between the two parts, the head and the heart. The result is that man's misery has increased. Imagine a man with a very big head and long hands and legs but a very small heart—what a ludicrous cartoon it will appear. There are religious fueds, racial conflicts, language controversies and industrial disputes going on everywhere in this world these days. This is all a manifestation of the war going on between the mind and the heart. You cannot reduce the area of intellect and so you have to widen the heart. And one has to start with oneself. That is why I have come here, and have profitted thereby.

After the bath, when Vinoba had been in his room, a Maharashtrian Muslim came to him. Kalindi Bahin writes in her diary:—As I entered the room, I saw a gentleman seated on Baba's cot talking to him and Baba laughing. Baba said, "You were with me in Nagpur jail and we were together for six months. After release, you went to Calcutta to join your business and thence to Pakistan. It is good that you came to see me." The gentleman replied, "I was told that you would not recognise me. But I was sure of it. I could not come earlier due to some domestic preoccupations. Everywhere people are quarrelling over religion, Caste and ism. You alone after Bapu are capable of stopping all this. There has been sharp criticism in the newspapers here on your 'Essence of Quran'. I told them that you could not utter a single unbecoming word." Baba said, "Give publicity to that, you will be thereby serving Islam." Turning to me he said, "Talk to him in Marathi." He was once at Hinganghat near Wardha. I never imagined that a Muslim gentleman could talk to me in Marathi in a village in E. Pakistan. At ten O'clock, Baba spoke to the members of the party. He said, "The mind and the heart should be in harmony. I had no idea of the extent of enthusiasm that we see here. Perhaps you know that I had not approved of the suggestion of sending an advance party here to create a suitable atmosphere for my mission. For, I had faith in the people. Even if the Govt. had not made any arrangements, the response would have been the same. I have come from one country to another and that also as its representative. Pandit Nehru wrote to the Pakistan Govt. in this connection and so they have naturally made elaborate arrangements. History records that big political movements were preceded by cultural movements and there was some ideology behind them. The concept

of the World State is sure to gain ground. Not that it will take shape within a couple of years, but you will be the fore-runners of the future social revolution. We shall keep away from power politics, and not sponsor any candidate for election. If you proceed in this spirit with the message of love, none will be able to deter you. My 'pad-yatra' is a proof of that. The Pakistan Govt. could have withheld permission for my entry into this country on the plea that it might increase tension here. Had it happened, it could not have been blamed for that. But they permitted me. Mohammadali has said, 'The pad-yatra will have its effect not only in India but throughout the World.'

We shall work with fore-sight. The saints and sages had a very broad outlook; theirs was a cosmic vision. Our work is to unite hearts, to inculcate fearlessness, and give up all fear rising from attachment to body, fear of calamity falling on our person, property or children. Often it is the latter type that has a powerful influence. During the civil disobedience movement, people were more afraid of fines and confiscation of property than imprisonment. It is the work of Saints and Sages to free people from that fear.

The other day, there appeared in the Morning News an article by a Muslim writer on Vaishnavism. In it Sufism was compared to Vaishnavism and he pointed to the potentiality of the latter to inspire people in every age and to the inner truth it contained. The litterateur always sees the truth of a higher plane. 'The Essence of Quran' is an humble effort in that direction. You will please take up the work of inculcating fearlessness, social service etc. with such broad vision. Let the people shoulder the responsibility of running village industries; you have to guide them without being involved wholly in it. The Govt. too will slowly play its

part. The work of social unity and widening the sphere of love has to be taken up. Social dinners and silent collective prayers are powerful means of wide social contacts. The ideology of World State should have in its back-ground the highest concept of One God and human unity. The place of service will automatically be there."

Replying to another question Vinobaji said, "Keeping Gramdan in the centre, you have to organise other activities of service to the poor e. g. Bhoodan, Sarvodaya Patra etc. In India I advised the use of the Sarvodaya Patra rice for the maintenance of workers but here rice, money, everything should be used directly for the service of the poor. The workers shall be maintained by their friends.

The literature that you propagate should appeal both to the Hindus and the Muslims. Effort should be made to enrich the language with an attitude of humility and love and not superiority. We shall so work that it will not inhibit our mobility. There can be a central place where the members of the mobile unit may go for rest for a short period when unwell or in response to an urge for a quiet life and then return for active work with greater vigour. The workers should devote themselves to study also, but it may not be possible for all. In that case those who study should share their knowledge with others. Noakhali must have such an Ashram."

At about 2 P. M., some prominent Santhals came and sat quietly near Baba. They were quite conversant with Hindi. Baba asked, "Nobody drinks I suppose?" They replied, "None" by the movement of the head. "Will you donate land?" was the next question. One of them replied, "We have no land. All the land has been acquired by the Govt. for the Farm. We now live on wages by working there."

They kept sitting for some time as if in a woeful silence, then bowed and left the place. They appeared to be in deep despair.

Today a teacher from the Dacca Girls High School, Begam Salina Banu joined our party. I told her that she could have an interview with Baba any time she desired. She expressed disinclination and added, "What is there in an interview? To be with him and hear him is a sufficiently welcome opportunity and happy privilege."

At 4-30 P. M. the evening meeting commenced. Addressing a gathering of about 10 thousand people Baba said :

"Today is my fourteenth day in Pakistan. Two days more for me in Pakistan now. More facts are known to the children of today than adults of the bygone ages. With the increase of knowledge, man's wants have multiplied and various facilities, medical and others are available to him. Still he is unhappy. His range of knowledge has become very wide, articles of consumption are plenty and varied, still they fall short of giving satisfaction to his increasing desire for enjoyment. Knowledge has increased, not so love. Intellectually he has grown much, but remains poor emotionally, rather poorer. As such, suffering is his lot.

This desire for more and more has gripped men the World over and has given impetus to mutual contact and means of transportation. The world has become one in the matter of multiplication of desires but unfortunately love remains imprisoned, a captive in our small room. The desires have rendered man so self-centred, so engrossed in the pursuit of pleasures that he has no time to look at others. Had there been a feeling of human brotherhood, there would not be cut-throat competition among various countries and the World's production of various commodities would be planned on a World

level without causing conflict of interests. In that event, even the multiplication of wants would cause no harm. That is why wise people are advocating immediate establishment of the World State. There is a talk of U. K. joining the European Common Market and the question is being discussed as to its probable effects on trade with India and Pakistan. But the need is for the World Common Market—we must understand which way the World is moving.

There is a book by a Chinese author—‘Tale of a prosperous village’. He writes that food materials and all other articles of basic need were available there and so none stirred out of the village, not even to the neighbouring villages. When I had been in jail during the struggle for independence, I saw prisoners counting the number of days after which they would be released. The days of nations remaining isolated or isolating others are over. All have to come close or else every thing will perish. If man uses weapons of destruction in a frenzy of violence and counter-violence, the human race will be exterminated from this earth. Man has to keep in control this terrific power that he has created. Fear and hostility gave birth to it; now fearlessness and love should stop any wrong use of it.

If all power vests in a few hands, the world will slip into a terrible plight. The only solution is establishment of Gram-Swarajya in every village throughout the country and through it that of the World State. Then only the World will escape disaster. What will be our part in the attainment of this objective. We shall have to extend the sphere of love in every village. Knit it into one family by giving Bhoodan. Just as fear and hostility prevail among nations, similarly they exist among individuals in villages. Village, will have to wipe out all differences and divisions and forge unity. Then

only will World problems be solved. The sum of the three angles of a triangle will remain the same irrespective of whether it is big or small. The size of letters does not change the meaning of a written material. What exists at the village level is also found at the world level. The village is a world abridged; the World is a village enlarged. If we can usher peace in a village through love, then we are in a position to do that in the World. Hence my appeal for Bhoodan, cessation of interest-taking and unity. When planning for the village will be done in the village itself, when ownership of all the land will pass on to the village, when village industries will thrive and none will charge interest, then Gram-Swarajya will be established. The Union Councils of Basic Democracy can undertake the work of village reconstruction on the basis of love. One man's woe in a village shall be felt as the suffering of all; similarly joy will be shared. When shared, happiness multiplies, while misery is lessened."

There was silent prayer after the meeting. No Bhoodan was declared today for reasons unknown. Those who had land were men of importance and kept at a distance from us.

POWER OF THE PEOPLE VS. POWER OF THE STATE

The fifteenth day

We arrived at our today's destination, Dinajpur Circuit House at 7.30 A. M. Addressing the people assembled there Baba said :

"It is a big town and a large meeting is expected. Tomorrow's camp will be at a small village and the day after I leave Pakistan. God willing, I may come here again. During the last fifteen days I had full taste of your love. 'Love begets love'—this I speak from personal experience. What can I give you in return ? I want you to express your love by giving in Bhoodan and serving the poor. It is true that the care of the people is govt.'s responsibility. But the labour and strength of the people is the first pre-requisite for any work. Shall we look on waiting for the Municipal fire-brigade in case of an outbreak of fire or make efforts ourselves at extinguishing it with bucketfuls of sand and water ? The more fierce it is, harder will be our efforts to control it. Full benefit can be achieved only when Govt. aid has the support of the labour and strength of the people. Both are essential components of progress. To my mind the latter has a higher place. I have no idea of the Plans in Pakistan, but in India they are going to spend 5,800 crores of rupees on the Five Year Plan. It amounts to one anna per head per day. So I call it 'one-anna Plan'. You will now realise how feeble is Govt's. power compared to that of the people. Instead of looking to the Govt. for help, if you work in co-operation, it will be a real

contribution for progress. Govt. aid can push it up further. Those who have no land to donate can render service by their intellect, knowledge. They can take up the work of literacy. If one educated person is able to make ten persons literate, there will be no illiteracy in Pakistan. The same work through the agency of the Govt. will entail a huge expenditure and much time, while you will be able to accomplish it without spending anything and in a short period.

I have no property, no house, no bank balance, no land. Others own large buildings. But I reside everyday in a new house, neat and clean, well-decorated; I do not even have to worry about my food; people arrange it for me and look to other conveniences also. Those who give with both hands receive from thousands. The Quran says, 'Your wealth will increase by giving in charity, not by charging interest.' That is why you should give as much as possible in Bhoodan, Sampattidan, Shramdan, Buddhidan for the poor." At ten O'clock discussions with the workers commenced. Baba said :

"The least that the workers should do is to live as members of the same family with their co-workers. Even though they may be engaged at different places and in different work, there shall be a feeling of brotherhood between one another. The villagers will be influenced by how we live, and behave with each other. I am re-reading the New Testament. It says as to how the followers of Christ lived after his death : 'They sold their possessions...preached amongst men begging from house to house...became one in heart and soul...nobody thought for himself but for all.' The followers of Christ gave up their personal property in a spirit of human brotherhood. The communists too say the same thing; they propose to do it on a State level which implies use of force.

This will render the work hollow, while that done on a personal level will be real. There will be personal contact, man to man approach in the latter case and that alone is effective as it is not coercive.

The difference in emoluments of workers results in differences of standards of living. If all are given the same scale, it fosters fellow-feeling and love. If workers devote themselves to work in this spirit, it creates a very congenial atmosphere. They shall not take any loans personal or collective from any source private or governmental."

After the talk with the workers had been over, the Deputy Commissioner, Mr. Hasan came with a present of books on behalf of the East Pakistan Government. After his departure, members of the local Bar Association came. Kalindi Bahin narrates in her diary :

Talks with the Bar members began :

"What is the number of practitioners here?"

"About 50-60."

"More than enough."

"No, sir, the figure is rather low."

"Oh, then people have risen higher in morality!"

That evoked some laughter. Baba then said to them, "Then, why not go to villages and plead my case for Bhoddan?" In the afternoon a lady entered with a child. She boldly went near Baba, took her seat and asked, "Baba, there is so much conflict, violence and counter-violence in the world. What is the way out?" The lady was a local officer's wife. Baba replied, "The ladies should take up this work." Before departure, holding her son in front of Baba she said, "I offer my son to you. I wish that he may one day take up this work of yours." The child was afraid and clasped to her mother more tightly.

The prayer meeting commenced at 5 p. m. About 15,000 people had gathered. Addressing them Baba said, "I shall be in Pākistān for a day more. Were it possible for me to converse with you in Bengali, I would be more close to you. I have been studying this language for the last forty years. I can understand it but cannot speak. It is a very sweet language. Several great men have contributed to its sweetness and virility. It had the impact of Vedic, Vaishnavic, Buddhist and Islamic religions. It has also been influenced by the modern thought commencing from Ram Mohan Roy. It has been enriched by the Dhyān-Yoga of the Vedas, non-violence of the Buddhists, love of the Vaishnavas, and orthodoxy of the Muslims. Eight crores of people speak it. Its special feature is that it has no genders, and so the love described in its literature is immaculate. When this is translated in other languages, it smacks of some sensuality. It has a grandeur of its own. That is why, I have great regard for the Bengali language. More the number of cultures that fuse in a language, more vigorous it becomes. Even music attains its brilliance in such a language. When I hear a Bengali song, my heart throbs. One not only hears it, but is also awakened, is made to dance, is inspired. This language is a great heritage. It must flourish. It claims a greater number of translations in Hindi than any other language. I am sorry that I could not express myself in it today.

Some teachers came to me today. I told them in reply to a question that in future the work of litterateurs and teachers will assume greater importance. The power of science can produce as well as destroy. Just as fire, steam, electricity and nuclear energy can be harnessed for the benefit of man, so also they can bring complete destruction. Who will direct its proper use? It is the work of the litterateurs and teachers.

Their work is to synthesize the old and the new. The nature of the new is to move on in the front and that of the antique is to drag back. They are engaged in a struggle. The *new* has power, the *old* has 'Rasa', savour. To blend them in one is the work of the teacher and the litterateur. It is the work of the teacher to hinge the spiritual experience of the past to the science's onward march of the new. It is a big task. If these two forces are at cross-purposes, the old will tatter and lose its content and the new will miss its mission and roll down towards destruction. It will not do to get stuck up in the literal meanings of the (Shastras) scriptures of the old—the esoteric meaning will have to be grasped in the light of the new—let the new move forward. When children accompany me, I make way for them and encourage them to get ahead. Thus it is not wise to obstruct the onward drive of the new, it will be a futile attempt; the duty of the old is to control it, direct it. Hence the teacher and the litterateur should rise above political groupism and see and direct things remaining quite undetached.

Some people hold that the more the science progresses, the less will be the creation of poetry. They argue that poetry and literature need a large 'unknown' on which the imagination may play, for poetry cannot be composed on dry figures of science, which leave little scope for imagination. It is true that science widens the sphere of the 'known', but it also finds an ever-widening panorama of the 'unknown' before it. As such the scope for poetry and literature can become still wider. In the age of science a dog has travelled in the outer space. It would not do for any of us to feel insignificant. We shall have to look afar and exceed the narrow bounds of home, district and person. Those who think in terms of the

world, will have a say in this world. Science will turn to them for guidance.

In this region, the soil and the water are in harmonious proportions. That is why it has both the qualities of malleability and hardness and there is magnanimity of heart, I have said that I came to Pakistan to spread the message of love; but in reality the object has been to grow emotionally myself. I shall learn to love more than teach love. This was my experience on the very first day. A Muslim youth owning only 4 acres of land gave away one acre in Bhoodan. I was impressed by this simple youth, not very literate, and his example inspired me to love more. A friend asked me today as to how I got the idea of Bhoodan. I had gone to Telangana in South India. The people there were harassed by the communists at night and during the day the Police would trouble them on the ground that they had given shelter to the communists. Ravages of communist insurgents at night and excesses of the Police and the Army by day ! They had to live in constant panic. Hundreds of Zamindars and Jotedars were murdered. When such a state of affairs was prevailing I went there. One day in a Harijan village, I was told that Harijans there, all landless, would manage for their livelihood if they were given land. With faith in God I asked for land and a friend responded immediately. I could not sleep that night. 'What can be the God's will?' I pondered. I conversed with Him and heard His voice, "Do not worry, have faith and go on asking for land." The next day, some villagers offered me breakfast. I agreed on the condition that they would donate land for the landless. And they consented. I got the second donation and since then I have been wandering on foot asking for land for the last twelve years. I have come here with the same message. There I got one Bhoodan

on the first day and here too one on the first day. I shall never forget the tears of gratitude rolling down the cheeks of that Muslim Youth on my first day in Pakistan when I told him, "May God bless you!" I shall make a mention of that event in India. May God inspire all to adopt this great ideal!

The meeting terminated after the silent prayer for five minutes.

XVI

LOVE DISSOLVES ALL OPPOSITION

The sixteenth day.

We reached our day's destination, Viral, at about 7 A. M. and were camped in the High School building there. About 700-800 people had assembled. Addressing them Baba said:

"Today is my last day in Pakistan. The memory of the last day is lasting. The feelings of that day settle down in our memory and are stored there. The same holds true in case of our terrestrial existence. We shall have fulfilled ourselves if the last day of our life is passed in peace, in remembering God, if the touch of our near and dear ones is sweet, if the day passes in an atmosphere of love. The Sadhaks (aspirants) lead a life of austerity, serve the people, remember God and face hardships in course of their pursuit of alleviating suffering of others, so that their last day of life may pass in peace and love. This is a day of our trial. If we get through it well, then that life is a success. We want to enter heaven after death without doing any good in this life! It is just like a child wanting to be declared successful in the examinations without devoting to studies. In the Quran it has been said, 'Those who repent for every bad act done by them, don't have to repent on the last day.' The name of this village is 'Viral' i. e. unique and so I hope that it will give me 16 Bhoodans on my sixteenth day in Pakistan. Those who give shall please name the donations too. As for me, I came empty handed and shall go empty handed."

At 10 A. M. Baba sat for discussions with the constructive workers. He said:

"Vishwaranjan has asked a question, 'What should be the

duty of a worker if people do not co-operate?' The first thing that he has to do is to strive for greater purification. Then, if necessary, he should change the place of work." In reply to another question Vinobaji said, "There are many ways of neutralising antagonism among workers. The first is, padyatra. During that period we shall take care that we do not allow our defects to appear before others during a day's halt. By daily practice, our shortcomings will be reduced and virtues will grow, thus reducing occasions for outer conflicts to a minimum. The second method is, to let bygones be bygones, to turn away from all the past rancours. The third way is to bear in mind that there is always a change in man—each of us is new-born every day. Yet another method is to sit in a group every week for *tete-a-tete*, when everyone should give vent to his feelings and remove misunderstandings that may have cropped up among them. Misunderstandings should not be allowed to grow, for they have a tendency slowly to get hard and thick when it becomes difficult to clear them. So the best thing is that they should not be allowed to take roots. Those who are sensitive get easily excited and are prone to pick up quarrels; ordinary things assume a magnified image. For them it is necessary to see God in everybody, failing which discords are sure to come their way.

Man's ego is a great impediment in the way of composing mutual differences. It is difficult to find out a powerful man sans egotism. When a man realizes where really the source of his strength lies, he sheds his egotism. When he ponders as to what favourable circumstances have contributed to his power and its growth, he finds out the source. He is not the owner of his knowledge, his power, it is the society that owns it. He is only a trustee, care-taker. All his virtues belong to the society not to the individual.

Unity is not difficult to achieve among you. You have the boon of God—adversity. Kunti asked for this very boon from Lord Krishna, for she could then take shelter in Him. You too have that boon granted to you.” Vishwaranjan then raised another point, “You talk of seeing others’ virtues and overlooking their defects. But often it so happens that defects of someone have to be pointed out in the pursuit of truth. Not to do that is likely to cause misunderstanding. What should be our duty in such circumstances?” Vinobaji replied, “One can take such a detached view that he may overlook defects and see the truth alone. But if in practical life defects force attention, then one may say and do, with love, what is absolutely necessary to draw the co-worker’s attention to improve himself.”

In the after-noon, prominent persons of the village came to see Baba. In course of the discussions he said to them, “During these days it has struck me that the people are loving and generous, but there is a dearth of social workers. The Govt. servants do render service but they have power, authority; theirs is not a voluntary service. Unless people volunteer for selfless work, there can be no progress. We may depend on the Government for every thing, but we too should play our part. If the members of the Union Council so choose, they can do public work. People will elect only those whom they love and rely upon.

The Christians have rendered much service in this country; very few instances like theirs have come to my notice. They have served in all fields—hospitals, schools, dissemination of literature, service to lepers etc. The country will not progress until selfless workers come forward. A Christian friend of mine served the lepers for a number of years. Subsequently he too fell a victim to leprosy. But that made no

difference in his attitude. He said, "God has sent this malady to me only to enable me to understand through experience the severe pain through which some patients pass." He is serving the lepers even though he has been attacked by the disease. Even a couple of such workers can render great service to the country. One hundred and fifty Bighas of land that I have got in Bhoodan will suffice to provide livelihood to one hundred persons. Thus it is apparent that you can make yourself useful if you put in some labour."

The prayer-meeting commenced at 5 P. M. Addressing a gathering of about 14 to 15 thousand people, Vinoba said: "Today is my last day in Pakistan. God willing, I shall leave tomorrow. During the last sixteen days I have seen love flowing out through your eyes. The whole society should strive for two things,—love for each other and fearlessness. God has purposely created more than one race, one language, one religion in order to produce diversity. He could have as well created a single race, a single religion, a single language. There is an interesting story in the Bible about it. The people of Babylonia started construction of a huge minar. They imagined that God was high up in the heaven and one could see Him by climbing up the tower. God proposed to stop this foolish work. One day all of a sudden He created many languages among them. Now when one was asked to fetch bricks, lime was brought, and something else when asked for lime. Thus the construction of the minar was stopped on account of the confusion that resulted. The lesson of the story is that God purposely created a number of languages. Whatever may be the divisions and variations, we should understand that we are one as homo sapiens. There may be a number of religions, sects, languages, races and parties. Yet humanity is one, and comprises one

family. We should attain this state and that will be only through love. God has bestowed upon us love and it will flourish only in diversity.

The other virtue is fearlessness. With the growth of love, fear will vanish. In other words, so long as there is fear, true love will be absent. Fear and love are incompatible. The minorities fear lest the majority should suppress them. Those who are fearless will neither make others afraid of them nor fear anybody. Those who suppress others should be deemed as believers in fear, and are themselves afraid of those superior to them in strength. Such persons cannot be termed brave. One who succumbs to fear is a confirmed coward; similarly, one who overawes others is also a coward. However variegated the society may be, there should be no disharmony. Suppose in a family the eldest son earns a rupee, the second twelve annas, the third eight annas, the fourth four annas and the old father remains unemployed. Will they eat in proportion to their earnings and leave the father starving? No, all will be fed according to their needs. This is the rule of love on which harmony in a family depends. The same rule should apply to the society and then only will there be peace among the people.

In this age of science the concept of family should be broad-based. The days of small families are over. Take for example the problem of floods. Can 3-4 persons tackle it? The whole village, or a group of villages or three or four nations in a particular region will have to take joint measures to combat the menace. The river Brahmaputra has no partiality for one as against another nation. Consolidated efforts by 2-3 nations will have to be made to tame it. Small scale measures will not serve the purpose. Thus small families will not survive. We disapprove of the European Common

Market lest it may affect us adversely. When small nations are finding it difficult to keep up their separate entity, how can small families do that? Some youths were asking me today as to what Bhoodan aimed at and why I had been moving from village to village for the last 11½ years facing heat, cold, rains and floods. My only object is to unite hearts. Some complain that I am further helping the process of fragmentation of land, and thus making cultivation still more difficult. But I have never advocated fragmentation. On the contrary I want that cultivation of land should be done in co-operation with all, that hearts should unite. When that has been done pieces of land too will be joined together. Those who do this work are loved both by God and the people. Will this rivulet of Bhoodan that has started flowing in Pakistan dry up? If some compassionate soul takes up this work, it will go on. Else it will stop. There is paucity of land here; it is so in several countries. The remedy is to harness science for increasing production. Bhoodan is not the sovereign remedy for all ills. Village industries like the spinning wheel etc. should be started. The oil-ghani is dying out because the village shoe-maker buys oil from the Dacca oil mills and the village shoe-industry is facing hard competition because the ghani-owner purchases Bata's fancy shoes. Neither wants to support the other. If both insist on the village products, they will be mutually benefitted and ultimately the whole village, for money will not flow out of it. The best-played foot-ball or hockey match is that in which the ball is passed on from one to the other player. Similarly, when money is passed on from one hand to another, it will generate activity. All parts of the society should function in unison like those of the body; then only will their vitality be in it, then alone will there be



At Dinajpur

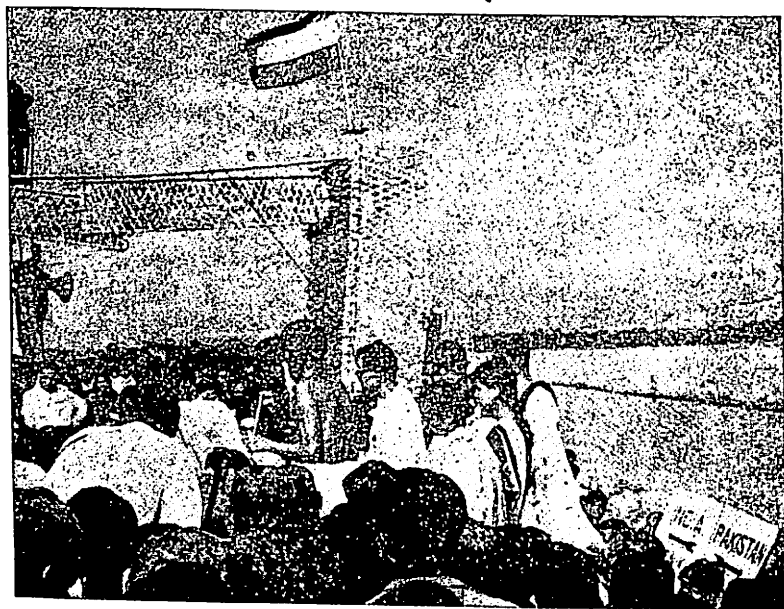


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Snapped in a rare pose, at Viral



Au revoir, Pakistan !



On the Indo-Pakistan border

all round progress; there will be no cause of anxiety or fear, cottage industries will find their proper place in the village economy, the land will be jointly owned by all, and the village will be happy and humming with life. ”

The meeting ended with the silent prayer.

Kalindi Bahin records in her diary :

I wonder if our contact with Pakistan will ever be cut off. It has been a memorable journey. Every event here will remain fresh in our memory, for it bears the impress of love.



XVII

THE DEPARTURE

At sun-rise we reached the borders of India. Speaking to a large gathering there, Vinoba said, "I am thankful to the Pakistan Government and its officials for making nice arrangements and facilitating my tour in E. Pakistan. I was not the least inconvenienced. The officials were very careful to make this tour as comfortable as possible. The workers who accompanied me have been sincerely serving Pakistan ever since Mahatmaji came to Noakhali. They acquitted themselves cheerfully during the sixteen days of my stay in Pakistan and rendered good service. I was happy in their company. They need no thanks from me. I only wish and hope that others may be inspired by their sincerity. I shall ever remember the love of the people of Pakistan towards me. I suppose that people numbering about a lac and a quarter have heard me. I shall never forget the silence and quiet that they observed at the time of prayers. It was a unique scene. The love evinced by them indicated that they had taken me as one of their own.

After touring the whole of India, I have come to Bengal. I hold this land in high esteem. There is no region in this world where great men have not taken birth. I have been much influenced by the great men of Bengal along with those of Maharashtra. I shall feel happy and satisfied if I can render even a little service to the people of this part.

After this short speech, Baba got down from the rostrum, cast a glance at the people smilingly and commenced his journey towards Radhikapur in the Indian territory.

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